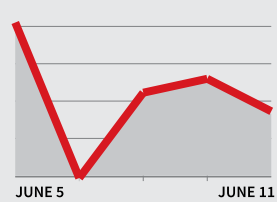


SENSEX 73832.55 (-150.63)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23161.60	-53.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.96	-0.04
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.76	+0.50
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	144202.00	-2355
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	232591.00	-692

PROBE FACES FLAK.

A year after the Air India crash in Ahmedabad, a pilots' body has questioned the direction of the investigation **p12**



THE HEAT IS ON.

Drought-bearing El Nino has set in while a positive IOD will emerge by July, says Jamstec **p10**

QUICKLY.

INNOVATIVE PACT

TCS, Anthropic partner to drive enterprise AI scaling



Mumbai: Tata Consultancy Services has announced a global partnership with Anthropic AI to scale enterprise AI adoption through early access to Claude models via a business unit. Recognising that most artificial intelligence initiatives in regulated industries stall at the pilot stage, TCS will bring Claude models to enterprises that demand accuracy, deep integration, resilience and strong governance. **p12**

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Rafale deal unlikely during PM Modi's visit to France

UNDER DISCUSSION. France 'engaging' with India's demand for access to source codes

Dalip Singh
Amit Sen
New Delhi



VOCAL FOR LOCAL. The current proposal stipulates that 90 of the 114 Rafale jets will be produced in India

The estimated ₹3.25 lakh crore government-to-government defence deal with France for 114 Rafale fighter jets is unlikely to be announced during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's upcoming two-day visit to Paris, starting on Saturday.

More significantly, the Macron government is engaging seriously with India's demand for access to source codes, which would allow the indigenous integration of weapons and systems.

Another issue under extensive consideration is India's push to execute the entire project under the 'Make in India' procurement policy, French diplomatic sources said on Thursday ahead of Modi's visit.

MAKE IN INDIA

The current proposal stipulates that 90 of the 114 Rafale jets will be produced in India, while the remaining 24 will

arrive in a fly-away condition.

SHIFT FROM THE PAST

This marks a significant shift from the two earlier Rafale contracts with France. When India purchased 36 Rafales for the Indian Air Force in 2016 and another 26 marine versions last year, all aircraft were acquired in 100 per cent fly-away condition — they were built, assembled and tested entirely in France by Dassault Aviation. This time, however, 90 of the fighters will be manufactured in India.

"Everything is open when the two leaders sit across the table," said French diplomatic sources, noting that India formally issued a letter of request (LoR) last month seeking a commercial and technical response for what will be its biggest-ever defence acquisition. "Both the French government and French companies are committed to integrating 'Make in India' into our defence deals, including the Rafale," said sources.

As negotiations move into the formal stages of finalising costs, Indian content and manufacturing cooperation, the bilateral procurement route is visibly evolving from a traditional client-provider relationship. "It's not a supplier-customer

relationship. It's equal to equal," said diplomatic sources.

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh earlier said that Dassault Aviation had offered 40 per cent localisation during initial discussions.

However, he stated that the Ministry of Defence is pushing for 50 per cent or more Indian content to boost self-reliance. For the first time, the aircraft will be manufactured outside France.

'DIFFERENT DEAL'

French diplomatic sources, too, reiterated that this contract is a departure from previous defence agreements.

"This Rafale deal will be different from earlier deals. Unlike the past, the integration of Indian components and weapons will be an inherent part of this contract," said a source.

Prime Minister Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron are scheduled to hold a bilateral meeting in Nice on Sunday.

US hits another ship with Indian crew near Oman; third in four days

Our Bureau
New Delhi

A Guinea-Bissau-flagged asphalt tanker, *MV Jalveer*, was attacked by the American military off the coast of Oman on Thursday. This marks the third merchant vessel manned by an Indian crew to be targeted by US forces in just four days. No casualties were reported in Thursday's strike.

The attacks began on June 8 when the US forces disabled Palau-flagged oil tanker *Marivex* carrying 24 Indian seafarers; all crew members were safely rescued. On June 10, the US military struck another Palau-flagged tanker, *Settebello*, killing three of the 24 Indian sailors on board.

Following Wednesday's strike, the Ministry of External Affairs summoned US Chargé d'Affaires Jason Meeks to hand over a demarche. "We attach high importance to the welfare and well-being of our seafaring community. When this attack on *Settebello* occurred, we lodged a strong protest with the American side," said MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal.

\$31 b shares up for sale in June-Sept on end of lock-in

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Shareholder lock-ins in 75 recently listed companies are set to expire between June and September, opening a fresh window for private equity (PE) and venture capital (VC) investors to monetise holdings through block deals, with exits expected to be staggered amid volatile market conditions.

Data compiled by Nuvama Alternative and Quantitative Research show shares worth about \$31 billion becoming eligible for trading by September 28. The lock-in for Meesha expired this week, opening up 3,083 million shares, equivalent to 68 per cent of its outstanding equity. Aequus's lock-in expiry opened 146 million shares on Tuesday.

Next week, 923 million shares of Vishal Mega Mart and 344 million shares of ICICI Pru AMC become eligible to trade. Other unlocks for June include Wakefit Innovations, Corona Remedies, Nephrocare Health Services, Oswal Pumps and Sai Life Sciences.

VOLATILITY WOES

These expiries come at a

time when the volatility in equity markets has slowed the pace of fresh listings, making secondary transactions a key exit route for pre-IPO investors. While half of these companies are still trading at a premium, almost all are in the red from their highs since listing.

BLOCK DEALS

Investment bankers said institutions are evaluating stock liquidity and investor depth to absorb a meaningful block without near-term price pressure. While block deals will continue to be a strong theme over the next year, sales are likely to take place in a staggered manner rather than through large one-time disposals.

"Where the lock-in window is no longer a constraint and there is enough market depth to support block trades, we expect sponsors to continue evaluating exit windows," said Abhishek Dadoo, Partner at Khaitan & Co.

"Execution is likely to depend on valuation support, earnings visibility and the ability of the market to absorb supply without significant disruption. A staggered or calibrated sell-down is increasingly the preferred route," said Dadoo.

Petrol with 22-30% ethanol blend exempted from central excise duty

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The Finance Ministry on Thursday issued a series of notifications exempting petrol with an ethanol blend of 22 per cent to 30 per cent from the Central excise duty.

However, the Oil Ministry noted that these higher blends will not be rolled out until extensive testing and stakeholder consultations are complete.

Petrol with blending of up to 10 per cent is so far exempt from the duty. For unbranded petrol, the duty is ₹11.90 per litre, while for branded it is ₹13.10/litre.

APPLICABLE TAXES

The fresh notification specifies that a zero excise duty will apply to 22 per cent ethanol-blended petrol, which is a mix of 78 per cent standard



petrol and 22 per cent ethanol, provided all applicable Central, State or Union Territory taxes have been paid on the base ingredients.

The fuel must also meet Bureau of Indian Standards specifications. Identical tax exemptions apply to 25 per cent, 27 per cent and 30 per cent ethanol blends.

However, the Oil Ministry clarified that while this tax relief is a necessary first step towards introducing higher

blends, it does not signal an immediate rollout.

CONSUMER INTEREST

The automobile industry believes that these changes must factor in the consumer interest. In a conversation with *businessline* recently, Shailesh Chandra, MD and CEO of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, had said: "From a customer standpoint, it is important that any potential impact on fuel efficiency from higher ethanol blends is adequately offset. The right and effective way to address this would be through appropriate pricing of ethanol-blended fuels, ensuring that the overall cost of ownership remains attractive for consumers."

"We have seen similar market dynamics in the case of CNG, where fuel pricing has played a key role in driving adoption," he added.

UDAN seaplane services from June 22 with Kochi to Lakshadweep ops

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The long-awaited seaplane services under the UDAN scheme are likely to commence on June 22, with operations between Kochi and Agatti in Lakshadweep expected to be inaugurated by Civil Aviation Minister Ram-mohan Naidu, sources told *businessline*.

According to sources, the final security clearances for the project have been received, paving the way for the launch of commercial seaplane operations in the island territory.

"Civil Aviation Minister Rammohan Naidu is likely to inaugurate the long-awaited services as final security clearances have been received," according to sources.

Details on p12

FTA effect: Price drop on British luxury cars in India

Bentley, Aston Martin, Rolls-Royce could be cheaper by ₹1 crore to ₹3 crore

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Luxury automakers are preempting the proposed India-UK Free Trade Agreement by slashing prices of British-built imported cars.

Car buyers can look forward to savings ranging from about ₹8 lakh on the Mini Cooper S to ₹75 lakh on the Range Rover SV, and as much as ₹3.32 crore on the McLaren 750S Spider.

For brands such as Bentley, Aston Martin and Rolls-Royce, the FTA could potentially trigger price reductions ranging from ₹1 crore to over ₹3 crore, depending on engine size and model specifications.

UNUSUAL INVERSION

But the proposed pact is also creating an unusual inversion in India's premium automobile market. While



DRIVE IN STYLE. Price of Mini Cooper S will fall by ₹8 lakh

some of the country's most expensive petrol-powered supercars and luxury SUVs are suddenly becoming dramatically cheaper, premium electric vehicles and hybrids remain excluded from the benefits and will continue to attract steep import duties for years.

McLaren Automotive and Jaguar Land Rover have already started revising prices downward in anticipation of lower import duties under the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), which proposes reducing

Customs duties on qualifying British-built completely built units (CBUs) from 110 per cent to 30 per cent initially, before tapering them further gradually under a quota-based system.

The biggest rebate so far is on the McLaren 750S Spider, whose ex-showroom price is expected to fall by ₹3.32 crore to ₹5.46 crore from ₹8.78 crore earlier. The McLaren 750S Coupe could become cheaper by ₹3 crore to ₹4.94 crore, while the McLaren GT may see a ₹2.32 crore reduction to ₹3.83 crore.

Jaguar Land Rover has reduced the price of the Range Rover SV by ₹75 lakh and the Range Rover Sport SV by ₹40 lakh.

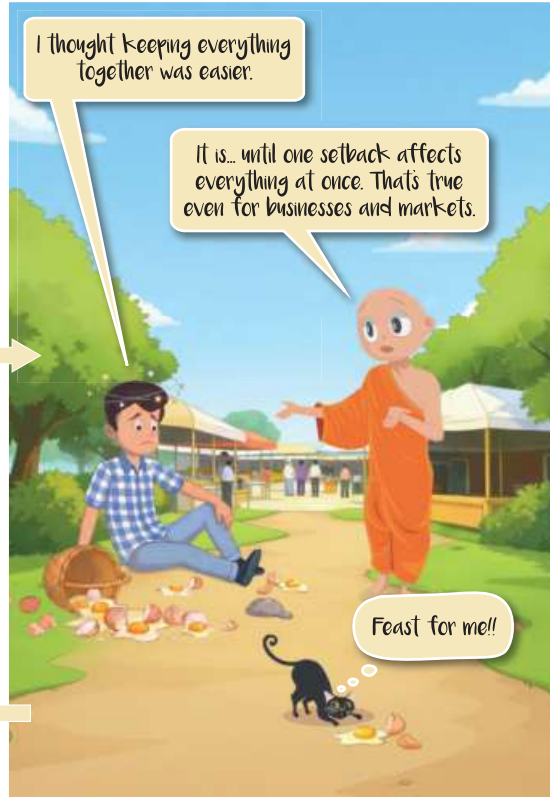
The duty relief applies specifically to imported British petrol cars with engines above 3,000 cc, putting the McLaren 750S Coupe, 750S Spider and GTS directly within the qualifying bracket.

EVs LEFT OUT

The biggest surprise in the agreement may be what it excludes. EVs, hybrids and hydrogen-powered models are locked out of duty reductions for the first five years after implementation.

Premium British EVs such as the Lotus Eletre, or the upcoming electric Range Rover, will continue to attract the high import duty structure through much of the decade.

A Monk Who Trades



DID YOU KNOW? Diversification is a widely used risk- management approach. Spreading investments across asset classes including commodities can help reduce risk.

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QUICKLY.

Deloitte India, SAP launch AI-led delivery centre



Bengaluru: Deloitte India announced the inauguration of its dedicated SAP Delivery Centre in Bengaluru. The AI-led innovation and delivery hub is designed to support SAP's transformation priorities, our BUREAU

Holoflex to invest ₹30 cr in second plant

Kolkata: Anti-counterfeiting and security solutions provider Holoflex said it plans to invest around ₹30 crore over the next two years to set up a second facility as demand rises for integrated physical and digital brand protection solutions. It currently has an unit in West Bengal and is considering locations around Delhi or in Gujarat for the proposed greenfield facility. **PM**

Sales of wheeled construction equipment fall 17.5% in May

BROAD-BASED MODERATION. Industry sees 20% dip in sales sequentially

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The Indian wheeled construction equipment (CE) market witnessed a sharp year-on-year decline in May 2026, with total industry sales falling 17.5 per cent to 5,088 units from 6,168 units in May 2025.

The decline was not only on a year-on-year basis, but also sequentially. Industry sales in May 2026 declined nearly 20 per cent when compared with 6,348 units reported in April, indicating a broad-based moderation in demand for wheeled CE.

While the wheeled CE market contracted sharply in May 2026, JCB, Escorts Kubota and Bull Machines gained market share, reinforcing their positions in an increasingly concentrated industry landscape.

According to FADA Research data, JCB India sold

Wheeled construction equipment industry struggles

Company	May 2025	Market share (%)	May 2026	Market share (%)
JCB India	2,414	39.14	2,265	44.52
Action Construction Equipment.	712	11.54	632	12.42
Escorts Kubota (Construction Equipment)	378	6.13	401	7.88
Ajax Engineering	465	7.54	388	7.63
Bull Machines	139	2.25	179	3.52

Source: FADA Research

2,265 units in May 2026 (2,414 units). Despite a 6.2 per cent decline in sales, its market share jumped to 44.52 per cent (39.14 per cent), gaining over 5 percentage points.

Action Construction Equipment (ACE) retained the second position with sales of 632 units (712 units), down 11.2 per cent. However, its market share improved marginally to 12.42 per cent (11.54 per cent).

Escorts Kubota emerged as one of the gainers during

the month. Sales rose 6.1 per cent to 401 units (378 units), while its market share increased to 7.88 per cent (6.13 per cent).

Among other manufacturers, the Coimbatore-based Bull Machines recorded strong growth, with sales rising 28.8 per cent to 179 units (139 units). Its market share expanded to 3.52 per cent (2.25 per cent).

ELEVATED BASE

The 17.5 per cent on-year decline in May 2026 retail sales,

compounded by a sequential drop of around 23 per cent from April, is consistent with a broader trend that has weighed on wheeled CE segment through much of FY26, a year that followed a high base in FY25.

The elevated base, combined with slower on-ground execution, has visibly weighed on fleet utilisation levels, which in turn has kept fresh equipment demand subdued, said Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings.

While government capex allocations remained at historically-high levels, delays in project execution, land acquisition challenges and slower disbursement cycles held back demand.

Unlike consumer-facing segments, CE demand is driven by on-ground contract activity, and seasonal softness ahead of monsoon adds to near-term pressure, she said.

Sectors that dominate India's start-up landscape beyond technology

Thillai Rajan A

The growth of India as one of the top four start-up nations globally has made the world take notice of our innovation prowess. Perhaps, India being an entrepreneurial nation traditionally, the start-up landscape in India is very different and in a way more secular compared to that of the west.

DATA FOCUS.

TOP SECTORS

Globally, start-ups are dominantly seen in technology sectors. However, in India, start-ups have been actively created in different sectors of the economy, apart from technology and related sectors. Based on an analysis of the number of start-ups formed during 2016-25, three of the top eight sectors in India were sectors such as food processing, food & beverage, and construction.

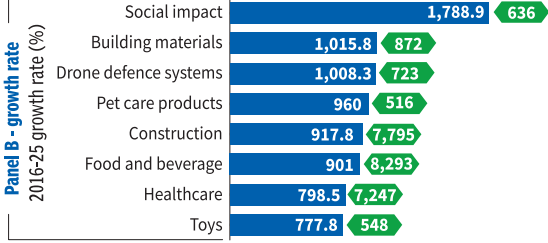
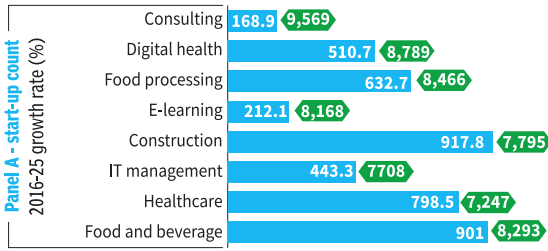
The top sectors by growth rate in the formation of start-ups includes sectors such as social impact, toys, pet care products and building materials. These are not the sectors that one usually associates with start-ups and have been unique to the Indian context. For example, India has now become known as the epicentre of Impact start-ups — founders who adopt entrepreneurial approaches instead of the traditional philanthropic route to solve challenges in the social sector. While the top sectors reflect the market opportunities for innovation products in the Indian context, it is also a manifestation of the traditional entrepreneurial strengths taking a start-up approach.

FUNDING FLOWS

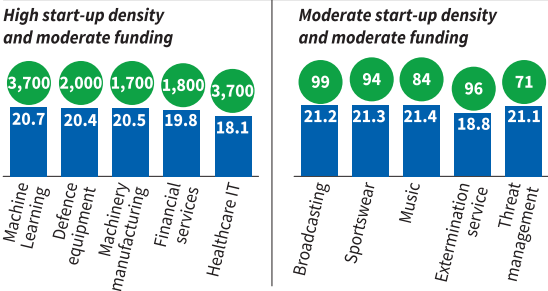
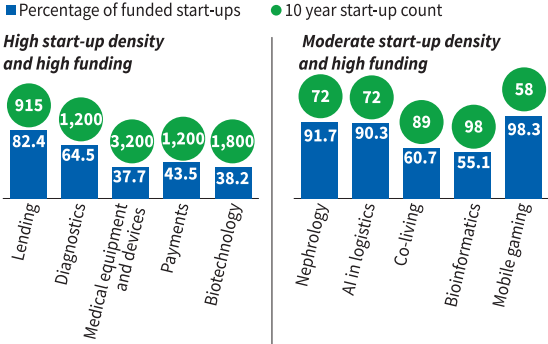
Fund raising from investors is an important activity for start-ups, since in most cases founders would be unable to bring in substantial capital on their own till the start-ups achieve sustainability. The top sectors by number of start-ups funded as well as quantum of funding shows that there are variations in the sectors where we see highest start-up activity vis-a-vis where we see maximum funding interest. For example, sectors such as clean tech, mobile apps, SAAS, AI, e-commerce, medical equip-

Trending sectors

Top start-up categories



The niche sub-sectors with high start-up density and high funding sectors



Source: YNOS Venture Engine

ment, fintech do not feature in the top sectors in terms of start-up formation, though they attract significant funding from investors. This goes on to show that start-up formation is not just a function of funding availability, but also depends on expertise, perceived market opportunities and the carrying capacity.

START-UP DENSITY

Sub-sectors such as lending, diagnostics, medical equipment, payments and biotechnology have large number of start-ups as well as a high percentage of funded start-ups. There are also certain 'specialised' sub-sectors, which may have very few start-ups, but have very high

funding percentage, such as nephrology and AI in logistics.

In summary, the Indian start-up landscape is dominated by sectors that are reflective of the local context and may be at variance with global trends; also, start-up formation has not necessarily been a function of funding popularity.

As they say, the most fundable sector isn't always the most crowded one; sometimes it is the quiet niche where almost everyone who shows up wins.

The writer is Professor, IIT-Madras, and Head, CREST, and Founder, YNOS Venture Engine. Research inputs from Chinmi Chaitanya and Dr Vamanie Perumal

Godrej Enterprises' ₹1,500 crore storage business taps domestic demand to offset export stress

Rohan Das
Chennai

Godrej Enterprises Group's storage solutions business is expecting strong domestic demand, led by expansion in e-commerce and manufacturing, to balance out the stress in export markets.

Speaking to *businessline*, Vikas Choudaha, Business Head - Storage Solutions, Godrej Enterprises Group, suggested that exports accounted for about 25 per cent of the storage solutions business in FY26, but given the current crisis in West

Asia, this could come down to 15-18 per cent this year. It currently exports solutions to 41 countries across the Americas, West Asia, Asean and Australia. Despite this, Choudaha added that the business, which manufactures warehousing infrastructure and industrial storage racks, can post a growth of 13 per cent in the current financial year. It had closed FY26 with a topline of about ₹1,500 crore.

WAR IMPACT

"Exports has seen some stress, but I think the domestic market can make up



Vikas Choudaha, Business Head - Storage Solutions, Godrej Enterprises Group

for it. Even in exports, we have already diverted focus towards Asia Pacific and other markets," he said. On the manufacturing side, Choudaha said the main

challenge has been the increase in oil and gas prices. "Steel prices had spiked initially, but the situation is a lot better now," he said.

Choudaha said that the rapid growth in e-commerce has been a strong tailwind for the industry with 30-35 per cent of the business now coming from the sector. "The growth of manufacturing industries, aided by PLI, has also created increased demand for large-scale warehouses and storage," he said.

The company currently has two dedicated facilities in Chennai and Bengaluru with a capacity of over one

lakh tonnes and 20,000 tonnes respectively.

The Bengaluru facility came as part of an acquisition, allowing the business to expand capacity in the near term. "We initially planned to set up another facility in Chennai with similar capacity. But setting up a facility of that size would have taken time and we needed the extra capacity sooner. The Bengaluru acquisition has given us a breather," he said.

However, plans for the new facility in Chennai are still on and he estimates about ₹400-crore investments to go into it.

China wins \$2.9 b Kenya airport deal

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Kenya has awarded a \$2.9 billion contract to China Communications Construction Co (CCCC) to expand and modernise Nairobi's Jomo Kenyatta International Airport (JKIA), marking a return to large-scale Chinese-backed infrastructure development nearly two years after the collapse of a proposed deal with Adani Group.

The contract value is roughly 50 per cent higher than Adani Group's proposed airport concession, which was estimated at about \$2 billion before being scrapped by President William Ruto's government in November 2024 amid political opposition, legal challenges and public scrutiny, sources said.

LG Electronics aims to double combined revenue in India, Brazil and Saudi Arabia by 2030

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
Seoul



Lyu Jae-cheol, Global CEO, LG Electronics

Consumer durables major LG Electronics is aiming to double the combined revenues in key growth markets of India, Brazil and Saudi Arabia by 2030. This comes at a time when the company is looking at strengthening global earnings through strategic measures, including cost competitiveness and future growth engines such as AI Home ecosystem.

Lyu Jae-cheol, Global CEO, LG Electronics, said, "India, alongside Saudi Arabia and Brazil, is at the absolute forefront of LG Electronics' long-term growth strategy.

"As part of our vision to double combined revenue in these three markets by 2030, we are aggressively accelerating our momentum across

these high-potential Global South markets."

"In 2025, our combined revenue from these regions reached KRW 6.2 trillion, delivering a growth rate of over 20 per cent compared to 2023. For LG, this hyper-growth in major emerging economies like India is not just about expanding our footprint; it is a strategic pivot to build a highly balanced, resilient regional portfolio that complements

our established strongholds in Korea, North America and Europe," he added.

LG Electronics' IR Communications Team Leader Aeron Kim said the company will double its production capacity in India to serve not just domestic demand but also grow share of exports significantly from the current levels of 6-7 per cent.

Besides shipping premium products to developed markets, it is also exporting India-designed "Essential Series" to emerging markets. LG India has facilities in Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra and is setting up a third in Andhra Pradesh.

AI HOME EXPERIENCES

One of the company's key bets is AI Home experiences with the "Zero Labour Home" vision. LG is building an AI Home ecosystem around AI-powered appli-

ances and ThinQ AI orchestration. It is also working towards building autonomous home robots.

In India, it began the rollout of this strategy in 2025 with the launch of its first AI washing machine and plans to expand its AI appliance portfolio later this year.

The company said that its manufacturing plants in India have been integrated into the global AI roadmap, ensuring that next-generation components are localised and scaled efficiently to support a broader rollout of AI-centric appliances in India.

Young Min Hwang, Director - Home Solutions, LG Electronics India, said, "We see momentum in this space and our premium products are experiencing rapid adoption."

The writer is in Seoul at the invitation of LG Electronics India

Jindal Poly Films' minority shareholders weigh options on apex court verdict

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The minority shareholders of Jindal Poly Films (JPFL) have raised concerns over the Supreme Court's decision to set aside the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) and National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) orders, dispose of the corporate class action suit with consent and appoint Justice (retired) Manindra Mohan Shrivastava as sole arbitrator.

businessline.

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The minority investors are currently evaluating the implications of the development and considering their next steps, said a lawyer representing the shareholders.

The dispute originated from a class action petition filed before the NCLT by minority public shareholders, alleging the siphoning of over ₹2,500 crore through undervalued transactions involving promoter-linked entities by JPFL.

LEGAL BATTLE

After a legal battle for about two years, the NCLT admitted the petition on February 5 and issued notice. SEBI intervened to place its investigative report, which confirmed a financial loss of over ₹760 crore to the public shareholders due to opaque related-party transactions, inadequate disclosures and violations of securities laws by JPFL promoters.

SEBI issued a show-cause

notice to the company, directing it to respond to the allegations raised by the minority shareholders.

Meanwhile, the NCLAT also upheld the NCLT's order on February 26 and dismissed JPFL's appeal challenging the maintainability of the class action.

In March, the lead petitioner, Ankit Jain, sold his shareholding and withdrew from the proceedings. Monet Securities, having acquired shares from Jain, stepped in as the substitute petitioner in May.

Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates, said that the decision to decline the class action proceedings and direct the dispute to arbitration undoubtedly comes as a setback for JPFL's nearly 44,000 retail shareholders.

However, it would be incorrect to assume that all remedies have been exhausted, she said.

How homeopathy and yoga shaped Bajaj Auto's growth strategy

Rajiv Bajaj shares three principles that helped the largely domestic auto-maker evolve into a global exporter

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Homeopathy and yoga may seem far removed from the motorcycle business but Rajiv Bajaj, Managing Director, Bajaj Auto, says both have influenced the philosophy behind his company's growth strategy.

Speaking at the launch of the Rupa Rahul Bajaj Scholarship for Women in Engineering, he said principles such as individualisation, holism and vitality have shaped the company's approach to innovation, problem-solving and capability building.

Twenty five years ago, Bajaj Auto was primarily an India-focused company. Today, it exports around 2.5 lakh vehicles every month to 108 countries and has emerged as one of the world's most valuable mo-

torcycle manufacturers by market capitalisation.

Bajaj said he takes "learnings from both homeopathy and yoga", explaining that the disciplines distilled his management philosophy into three principles borrowed from homeopathy: Individualisation, holism and vitality.

Individualisation is about recognising what makes a person or company unique rather than obsessing over comparisons.

Holism requires looking at challenges as part of a larger system rather than tackling them in isolation. Vitality is about building strength from within.

For Bajaj Auto, that final principle translated into a strategic decision to invest in internal engineering capability rather than depend on imported technology or external partners. He cited



Rajiv Bajaj, MD, Bajaj Auto

the company's journey from a four-member team that developed the Pulsar in 2001 to an R&D organisation of around 1,500 engineers today.

That focus on building capability from within, he argued, helped Bajaj Auto evolve from a domestic manufacturer into a global company exporting to 108 countries.

"One is to go out, bring

some consultant or bring some partner or adopt somebody else's technology. This is an outside-in approach. And one is to work from within — an inside-out approach," Bajaj said.

"Do you think without innovation we can do this? It doesn't happen without innovation."

FROM VITALITY TO CSR

On CSR, he said: "Create something remarkable", urging the scholars to build something distinctive, useful and enduring in whatever path they choose. For Bajaj, the principle of building strength from within extends beyond corporate strategy to talent development.

"The reason these girls are here is not because this is charity. They are here on their strength," Bajaj said,

referring to students who earned admission to some of the country's most competitive engineering institutions.

Bajaj also outlined three broader truths that he believes shape both business and life: Change, relativity and interdependence.

Invoking Charles Darwin, Bajaj argued that survival belongs not to the strongest or most intelligent, but to the most adaptable. Relativity, he said, is about continuous improvement, while interdependence recognises that progress is rarely achieved alone.

"All we have to do is be better today than we were yesterday," Bajaj said, summing up the philosophy behind both the company's growth strategy and its investment in the next generation of women engineers.

Game’s on
FIFA Cup promises to surprise and enthrall

For much of the past year, the FIFA World Cup has felt like a supporting character in its own story. The conversation around the tournament has been dominated by politics, immigration rules, border tensions, climate concerns and questions over whether a 48-team competition is a step forward or simply a bigger commercial enterprise for football’s global governing body.

However, once the opening whistle blows at the Azteca Stadium in Mexico City, where Diego Maradona inspired one of the World Cup’s most iconic triumphs in 1986, attention will quickly turn to what unfolds on the pitch. The central question of this World Cup is whether the game’s established powers can still hold off an increasingly ambitious chasing pack. Europe and South America have shared every world title, yet the events of Qatar four years ago suggest that football’s traditional hierarchy may not be as secure as it once appeared. Morocco became the first African nation to reach a World Cup semifinal, defeating Belgium, Spain and Portugal. Japan topped a group containing Spain and Germany, while Saudi Arabia stunned eventual champion Argentina in its opening group match. Those results, taken together, suggest that the line separating the contender and outsider is becoming increasingly blurred. Nowhere is that shift more apparent than in Africa. Morocco’s run to the semifinals in 2022 was hailed as a breakthrough, and four years later, the Atlas Lions return with much of the core that made history in Qatar. Senegal, led by Kalidou Koulibaly, Sadio Mane, and Ismaila Sarr, and Egypt, spearheaded by Mohamed Salah and Omar Marmoush, also arrive with aspirations of making deep runs.

The old guard, however, remains as formidable as ever. Argentina will look to become the first nation since Brazil in 1962 to successfully defend the World Cup, with Lionel Messi potentially making one final appearance on football’s grandest stage. France possesses extraordinary depth, with Kylian Mbappe leading another generation capable of dominating international football. Spain’s young stars, spearheaded by Lamine Yamal, are rapidly maturing, while England continues its search for a title since 1966. Yet none can assume the superiority that previous generations enjoyed. The expanded 48-team format will further complicate matters. More teams mean more unfamiliar opponents and greater potential for disruption.

But all contenders must first overcome obstacles unlike any seen in previous World Cups. Played across three countries, teams may move within days from the altitude of Mexico to the humidity of the American South. Several venues are also expected to experience demanding temperatures during June and July, making player management over a month-long campaign as decisive as any tactical innovation. Perhaps that is why predictions look unusually difficult. The favourites are obvious, but certainty is not. The 2026 Cup may still be won by Argentina, France, Spain, or one of the game’s other established powers. Yet it feels increasingly plausible that football’s next great breakthrough could come from elsewhere. For long, the World Cup has asked whether outsiders can challenge the elite. Now, the question is whether the elite can keep outsiders at bay.



Will tokenisation aid corporate bond market?

Global adoption of tokenisation has been patchy and may not address the inherent challenges in bond markets

POINT BLANK.
LOKESHWARRI SK

The SEBI Chairman made headlines recently when he said that at a conference that the regulator is exploring a pilot project to tokenise corporate bond market. He stated the pilot will examine if tokenisation can result in ‘faster settlement, better traceability, automated servicing and greater transparency’. This, in his view, could lead to improved liquidity in the corporate bond market. Whether tokenisation (explained below) can improve volumes in the corporate bond market is moot since this segment is grappling with several challenges including concentration of holding in the hands of large investors. But the Indian regulator is right in exploring tokenisation which is under active consideration of many of the major stock exchanges. It could well be the way forward, at least for some segments or functions of the stock exchange ecosystem. Tokenisation, or not, participation is already beginning to improve in the corporate bond segment in India as individual investors go hunting for higher yields. SEBI needs to do whatever it can to encourage this.

WHAT IS TOKENISATION? Tokenisation is linked to blockchain technology which came into prominence following the rise of the cryptocurrencies. IOSCO defines tokenisation as the creation, issuance or representation of assets on a digital token ledger or a programmable

platform. All the transactions in the tokens are recorded on these digital ledgers, which are transparent, secure and can be accessed by everyone. The idea is not new and has already been adopted in some countries, while other are still weighing it. According to the Bank for International Settlements, till July 2025, over 60 tokenised bonds have been issued, amounting to a total value of \$8 billion. Of these, there were 24 corporate bonds with a total value of \$3.8 billion, and 15 bonds issued by sovereigns, supranational entities and agencies (SSAs) with a value of \$1.9 billion. Government bond issuers in tokenised form include the Republic of Slovenia, Hong Kong SAR, the Republic of the Philippines, the Bank of Thailand, the European Investment Bank, the World Bank and the Swiss cantons.

NOT A SMOOTH PATH The idea of converting all securities — equities, bonds, derivatives — into tokens and enabling trading and settlement through distributed ledger does sound good as it will be faster, can bring down intermediation cost and perhaps improve liquidity. Settlement can take place in real time and bonds can trade in smaller fractions, improving demand. The BIS report found that the bid-ask spread was lower, at about 19 basis points in tokenised bonds versus 30 basis points in conventional bonds in the same category. But complete tokenisation of all financial instruments is quite some way

With most securities already dematerialised and trading in electronic form, there does not appear to be an urgent need to tokenise them

away. While newer issuances in some segments can be offered in tokenised form, transferring legacy transaction records on to distributed ledgers will be a monumental task. Partial tokenisation of markets is unlikely to be efficient. The infrastructure needs to be robust enough to ensure cyber security and handle communication with the clearing and settlement systems of the exchanges. The interoperability with other segments of the exchanges operating on legacy infrastructure is also likely to pose a challenge. While many countries are weighing this, 91 per cent of them have very limited or no tokenisation use cases, according to IOSCO. Most tokenisation transactions are still in pilot phase with few reaching significant scale. A survey done in 2025 shows that only 11 per cent of institutional investors have invested in tokenised assets, with 61 per cent expecting to invest by 2026. Most exchanges are moving ahead slowly in this due to the costs involved in the changeover and lack of perceivable benefit. With most securities already dematerialised and trading in electronic form, there does not appear to be an urgent need to tokenise them.

CURING CORPORATE BONDS While India too needs to keep pace with other markets and certainly examine the feasibility of tokenising some segments of the market, it is unlikely to be the panacea that corporate bond markets need. The inherent problems with the corporate bond market in India are well known — narrow issuer base with only the highest rated entities in the financial sector making most of the issuances, issuers preferring private placement route and most large investors preferring to buy and hold, thus affecting liquidity.

But the wind seems to be changing. Data from NSE’s pulse report show that the number of secondary market trades had more than doubled in FY26 to 28.4 lakh from 11.9 lakh in FY25. Value of turnover has increased 29 per cent in this period. Of note is that the number of individual investors has moved to 12.7 lakh by April 2026. The report also notes that individual traders accounted for 77.3 per cent of total trades, despite a very small share in value of turnover. There appears to be increased awareness among retail investors of late. It is obvious that the declining return in equity market and the hunt for higher yield are taking individual investors towards corporate bonds.

Companies have also been using this fund-raising route well, with outstanding corporate bonds standing ₹59 lakh crore. The increase in individual investor participation must be encouraged with more awareness campaigns. Online bond platforms, which enable buying and selling of corporate bonds in smaller denominations have played a part in kindling investor interest. These platforms should be allowed to grow, but with sufficient guardrails. Vigil must be maintained on these platforms to prevent mis-selling of riskier bonds as high-yielding propositions. The withdrawal of long-term capital gains tax with indexation on debt mutual funds has led to lower demand for these funds. This has resulted in share of turnover of mutual funds in secondary market for corporate bonds declining from 12 per cent in FY23 to 0.5 per cent now. Other institutional investors have also reduced their trading similarly, while individual investors have increased their participation. It may perhaps be good to bring back some tax sops for debt funds, to provide further impetus.

Right time to focus on sustainable agriculture

As a deficient monsoon looms, push to pulses and oilseeds, crop insurance and logistics support become important

A Amarendra Reddy
Tulsi Lingareddy

Indian agriculture, despite considerable progress in climate smart technology adoption, remains extremely vulnerable to changes in rainfall quantum and distribution with rainfed area accounting for half of the cultivated area. In addition, increasing extreme weather events and rising temperatures due to climate change are also affecting crop yields and farm incomes. For instance, number of days recording extreme weather increased to 331 in 2025 from 295 in 2024 and from 292 prior to that according to a report by Centre for Science and Environment. In this regard, the forecast of below normal rainfall at 90 per cent of long period average for 2026 is a cause for concern. It is crucial to build a resilient agricultural production system. Agricultural support policies since 1960s have been largely promoting cultivation of resource intensive crops like rice, wheat and sugarcane with assured procurement and input subsidies like free electricity. For instance, despite the forecasted below normal rainfall and the ongoing fertilizer supply constraints, the minimum support price (MSP) for

paddy has been increased by about 3 per cent for kharif 2026. Although the increase of MSP for paddy is relatively lower than that of pulses and oilseeds for kharif 2026, limited procurement and relatively low yields of pulses/oilseeds may not encourage farmers to shift from rice cultivation. Hence, there is an urgent need to address such imbalances in support policies that aid in exhaustion of natural resources and reorient them to promote resource conservation. Another important priority is to increase crop yields through promoting agricultural R&D and efficient transfer of technology. The yields of less water consuming crops like pulses and oilseeds have been stagnant for over decades, discouraging farmers from cultivating them. To boost their yield, 2,661 crop varieties tolerant to one or more biotic or abiotic stresses were released during 2014-2025 according to the Indian Council of Agricultural Research. Such efforts need to be continuous, and in line with changing climatic conditions and weather pattern.

SCALE UP FUNDING Towards this, funding for R&D needs to be scaled up not only for developing resilient crop varieties with enhanced yields and better cultivation practices to conserve resources, but also for their



CURB. Cultivation of resource intensive crops like paddy SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

efficient transfer from lab to fields. Apart from public funding, private sector, especially corporates involved in food and input retail chains, etc, may also be encouraged to voluntarily contribute to promoting agricultural research through CSR-like funding. Further, advanced weather forecasting system together with real-time crop advisory is crucial for building resilience in agriculture. With weather and monsoon patterns becoming more and more unpredictable in the recent years, an efficient system of forecasting using advanced AI-based models may help in predicting weather events and, thereby, facilitate real-time crop advisory. Crop insurance is another strategy that can protect farmers’ incomes. In this regard, the Pradhan

Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY), launched in 2016, has progressed well, covering 25-31 million hectares annually since 2018 (PMFBY portal). With the gross cropped area at around 220 million hectares, outreach of such insurance schemes needs to be expanded. Another crucial strategy, much discussed but with little progress, is connecting farmers directly with value chains for receiving better prices. Efforts towards this can be scaled up by leveraging the rapid progress in e-commerce, warehousing and logistics, akin to what producers in the manufacturing sector enjoy. Also, major corporates involved in agricultural food retail chains may be encouraged to help in on-boarding farmers with necessary logistics and outreach efforts. The successfully evolving organic farm product value chains illustrate the feasibility of such direct connection and integration of farmers. Thus, to meet the growing food and nutritional needs of a rising population, it is vital to build a resilient agricultural production system that promotes efficient and sustainable resource use.

Reddy is Joint Director, Policy Support Research, ICAR-National Institute of Biotic Stress Management, Raipur, and Lingareddy is Senior Economist, Sustainable Finance and Agriculture, Mumbai. Views are personal

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Telecom ruling

This refers to ‘Telecom relief’ (June 11). Although the Bombay High Court has ruled in favour of the telecom operators, the legal journey may not yet be over. The matter remains subject to further judicial scrutiny, and future proceedings could influence the outcome. Nevertheless, the judgment represents a significant milestone in the evolution of telecom regulation in India. At its core, the verdict is not merely about spectrum charges or telecom licences. It is about the relationship between the state and private enterprise. By reaffirming

that governmental actions must remain within legal and contractual boundaries, the court strengthened the principles of fairness, certainty, and the rule of law. These principles are indispensable for sustaining investment, promoting innovation, and supporting India’s long-term economic growth. The decision, therefore, stands as an important reminder that regulatory authority must always be exercised in a manner that respects both legal limits and legitimate business expectations. **Shivanand Pandit** Margao, Goa

Investor education

This refers to ‘Equity MF inflows slump 40% in May over April’ (June 11). The drop in equity mutual fund inflows is concerning but not entirely surprising. Persistent FPI outflows, geopolitical uncertainty, and flat SIP returns over recent vintage have tested retail investor conviction. What is encouraging is that SIP accounts remain above 9.64 crore, suggesting the broader participation culture is holding. The real risk is if consecutive months of muted returns trigger systematic SIP cancellations. Investor education emphasising long-term allocation

discipline, particularly among B30 city investors who are newer to volatility, deserves renewed attention from fund houses and AMFI alike. **Pon Arun Kumar** Tirupur, TN

Digital ecosystem

Apropos ‘How India can protect its digital ecosystem’ (June 11), Digital India has reshaped the lives of the millions of Indians, businesses, governance and financial sector in just a decade. At the same time, threats and mitigation techniques continue to

develop in the cybersecurity sector. Digital age necessitates a multifaceted approach to data protection. Strengthening legislative frameworks, enhancing transparency, fostering international cooperation, drafting Telecom Cybersecurity Rules, modernising cyber laws to address deepfakes and AI misuse, India can protect its citizens from rising cyber threats. Protecting the digital ecosystem also demands collaboration, foresight and adaptability. **P Victor Selvaraj** Palayamkottai, TN

Ensuring safe sports

A private body can focus on capability, compliance

GBS Bindra
Rahul Patwardhan

India's sporting ambitions have never been more visible. Public investment is rising, elite training systems are expanding, and Olympic performance is now seen as a marker of national capability. Yet, even as India builds for excellence, it continues to underinvest in something more fundamental: the safety of its athletes.

A recent disclosure in Parliament, noted that the Sports Authority of India (SAI) alone had received 33 complaints of sexual harassment over the past decade, of which 25 were against coaches. Equally significant was the admission that there is no consolidated national record of such complaints across sports federations, where a substantial share of organised sporting activity actually takes place.

These numbers are not merely administrative details. They point to a deeper structural issue. The absence of data, therefore, is not evidence of absence; it is often evidence of weak systems.

The challenge, however, extends beyond misconduct. Across disciplines, young athletes are frequently pushed into excessive training loads, resulting in avoidable injuries that curtail careers before they mature. Mental health concerns, burnout, anxiety, and distress remain under-recognised in environments that prioritise resilience but rarely institutionalise support.

The National Sports Governance Act, 2025 is an important step, establishing principles of athlete welfare, ethical conduct, and safe sport. But the effectiveness of any law depends on its implementation, and here the system remains underdeveloped.

The Act defines responsibilities, but it does not create the operational capability required to deliver them at scale. Federations and institutions are expected to comply, but they are left to interpret, design, and implement safe sport practices largely on their own.

Leading sporting nations have addressed this gap not by expanding government control, but by creating specialised, independent institutions that focus on prevention: training coaches, certifying competence, and auditing compliance in a standardised manner. India requires a similar approach.



SPORTS. For a safe ecosystem
RITU RAJ KONWAR

A National Safe Sports Institute, operating outside government but aligned with public policy, could provide the missing layer of implementation. Its role would not be regulatory or adjudicatory. Instead, it would focus on capability: developing multilingual, digitally delivered training for coaches and physical education teachers, introducing competency-based certification that tests judgment rather than attendance, and conducting independent audits to assess whether safe sport principles are embedded in everyday practice.

A technology backbone would allow this to be done at scale, standardising content across languages, issuing verifiable digital certifications, and creating a national evidence base for compliance. Such an institution would bring consistency. And it would shift the system from a complaint-driven model to a prevention-oriented one.

Importantly, this need not be a large or disruptive intervention. A pilot within the Sports Authority of India would allow processes to be tested in a controlled environment. From there, the framework could be extended to States that have demonstrated commitment to sports development, and eventually integrated into formal training pathways for future coaches and educators.

Equally important is the question of institutional design. A non-governmental structure with appropriate governance safeguards and representation from athletes and domain experts would allow such an institute to operate with both flexibility and trust while remaining aligned with national priorities.

India's sporting ambitions without safety is fragile. If the country is to build a durable and credible sporting ecosystem, it must invest not only in performance, but in the conditions that make performance possible.

The writers are Distinguished Fellows at the
Avinyum Foundation



V SRIDHAR
SHRISHA RAO

The AI economy is evolving from chat bots and conversational agents to instructing Robots to do physical tasks — aka physical AI — encompassing labelling, annotation, Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF), and prompt engineering.

Firms, mostly start-ups including HumynAI Labs, Egodata, and Neo Cambrian have deployed gig workers on the ground to label for physical AI and robotics AI to perform tasks such as housekeeping, plumbing, painting, and decorating to name a few, so that data from these processes are captured for training the models.

To enable this, digital platforms such as Encord, Labellrr, and Micro1 hire thousands of gig workers around the globe, equip them with depth sensing cameras and other accessories including Light Detection and Ranging (LiDAR) sensors to scan and annotate the physical world to be used by the physical AI and robotic companies. AI doesn't consist of only algorithms, but encompasses the invisible human labour beneath it.

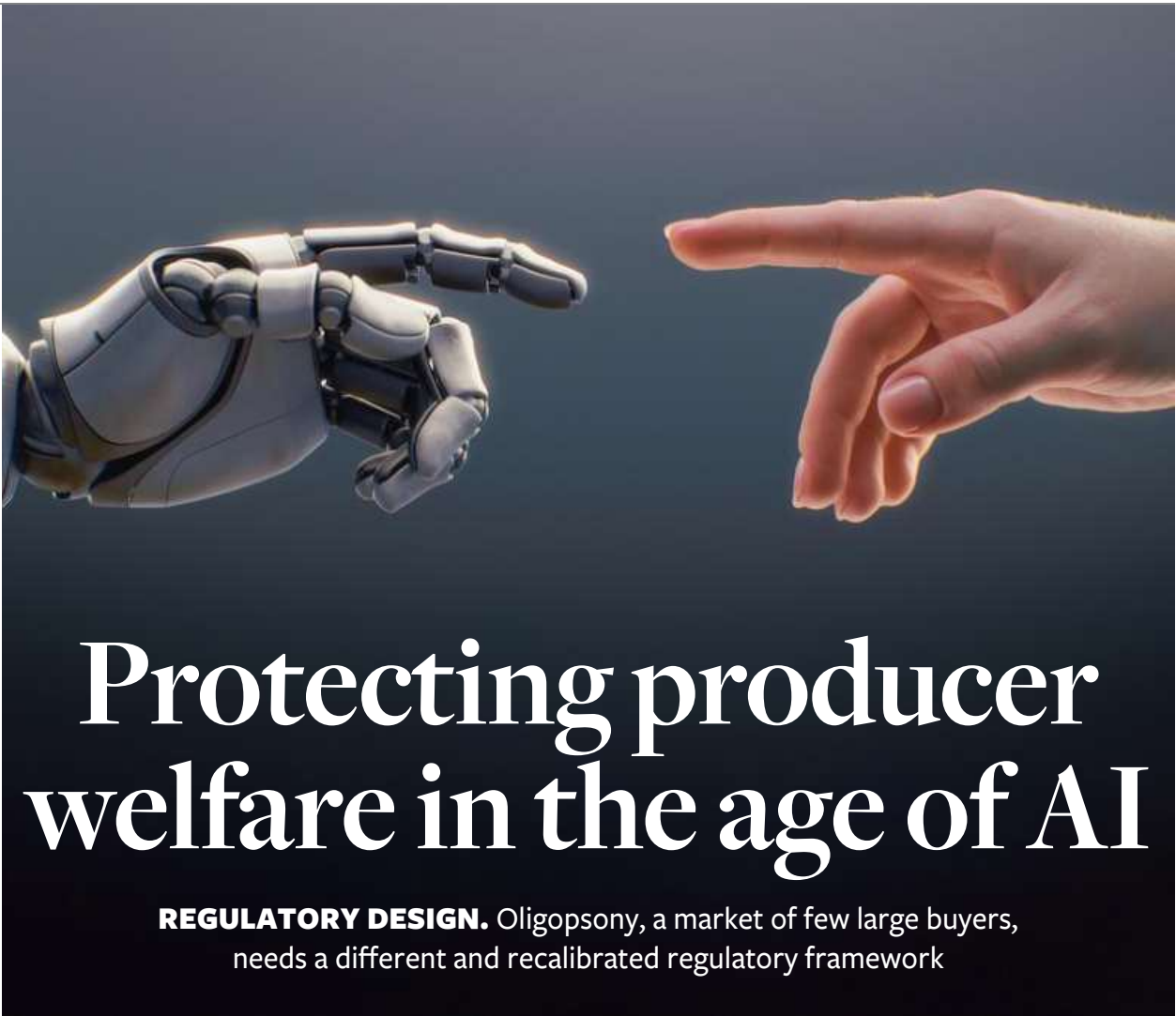
WORKERS WEAK POWER

These millions of gig workers who produce and feed content in to the AI algorithms often operate in an oligopsony market, where there are few physical AI firms procure their annotated content. The workers are often in a structurally weak position, and hence have a weak bargaining power with respect to wages, security and safety, amongst others.

While the regulations worldwide are focussed on monopoly or oligopoly markets, focusing on consumers and their welfare, privacy and data protection, they often are inadequate to address producer concerns. It is in this context that our research (accessible at: <https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/Delivery.cfm?abstractid=6716218>) provides insights in to the following important, often overlooked regulatory aspects.

First, is the importance of review and rating as signals of quality of work and workers in the above marketplaces. Platforms normally have a reputation system through which customer feedback about the quality of work carried out by the gig worker is routed, curated and published. Bayesian rating applied by most of the platforms require a threshold number of reviews to be materially effective.

Our research shows that a minimum



GETTY IMAGES

Protecting producer welfare in the age of AI

REGULATORY DESIGN. Oligopsony, a market of few large buyers, needs a different and recalibrated regulatory framework

of 800 transactions are required for the reviews to have any significant impact. This minimum threshold may weed out entrants and benefit only the first movers.

Further, most of the gig workers multi-home or switch platforms and if their reviews and ratings from one platform are not carried over to the other, they are disadvantaged. Hence regulators mandate portability of worker reviews across platforms, much the same way as the consumer data portability as mandated under the European Union Digital Markets Act.

COMMISSION FACTOR

Second is commission rates charged by the platforms, normally on the less price sensitive side — producer firms in this case. While the producer firms lobby for a commission rate cap to protect their profits, it is imperative that the regulators analyse the effect of such caps on the platform's ability to invest. Caps set too low may put pressure on the investment budgets of the platforms on infrastructure, cyber security and fraud prevention resulting in corresponding reduction in quality of artefacts in the marketplace.

Globally, no regulators have yet

prescribed a cap on commission rates on digital platforms, we caution against such caps on the producers especially in oligopsony markets where the negative effects may be significant.

Third, is the regulatory frameworks designed to protect consumers through quality assurance standards. Dictating minimum quality standards especially on the artefacts produced by the gig workers, increase compliance costs, credentialing burdens, and approval timelines, thereby discouraging newer gig workers to be part of this gig economy. Regulatory interventions on such minimum quality levels, though very much required in an oligopoly market, will have negative consequences

While the regulations worldwide are focussed on monopoly or oligopoly markets, focusing on consumers and their welfare, privacy and data protection, they often are inadequate to address producer concerns

When brands fall short, accountability matters more

Sita Mishra

When luxury fashion brand Prada unveiled its Spring/Summer 2026 collection, a pair of leather sandals sparked controversy for their resemblance to India's traditional Kolhapuri chappals. Social media users criticised the brand for drawing on a centuries-old craft without initially acknowledging its cultural origins.

Rather than remaining silent, Prada responded by recognising the inspiration behind the design and announcing collaborations and training initiatives involving artisan communities associated with Kolhapuri craftsmanship. As a result, the conversation gradually shifted from criticism to cautious appreciation.

The episode highlights a broader shift in consumer culture. Today's consumers do not necessarily expect brands to be flawless; they expect them to be accountable. While the controversy initially damaged Prada's



KOLHAPURI FOOTWEAR. Inspiring global brands
EMMANUAL YOGINI

image, its willingness to acknowledge concerns and engage with artisans strengthened perceptions of authenticity. Increasingly, brands earn trust not by avoiding mistakes, but by responding with transparency, humility, and meaningful action when mistakes occur.

For decades, marketers sought to build flawless brand images through carefully controlled communication and polished advertising.

Today, however, every campaign or

product launch faces immediate public scrutiny online. Social media has empowered consumers to challenge brands in real time, while rising concerns about cultural sensitivity, sustainability, and ethics have raised expectations.

As a result, accountability often feels more authentic than perfection. Consumers recognise that mistakes are inevitable; what matters is how brands respond. This aligns with the "Pratfall Effect," a psychological principle suggesting that competent organisations can appear more relatable and trustworthy when they openly acknowledge and learn from their mistakes.

TRUST, AN ASSET

Consumers today are quick to identify performative apologies. A brief statement without meaningful action rarely rebuilds trust. Instead, audiences expect accountability to be supported by visible change and genuine engagement. The Prada episode was not simply about fashion;

it was about recognising the communities and traditions behind creative inspiration.

Consumers expect accountability to be supported by meaningful action. Advertising may create visibility, but accountability builds trust and loyalty. In an era where authenticity increasingly drives consumer choice, the brands most likely to succeed are not those that appear perfect, but those willing to listen, learn, and act responsibly when they fall short.

This leaves brands with difficult but necessary questions. Are companies truly willing to learn from criticism, or are they only reacting to social media pressure? Are collaborations with communities meaningful and long term, or simply designed for positive headlines? In a marketplace increasingly shaped by authenticity, the brands that survive may not be those that appear perfect, but those that consistently act with honesty and responsibility.

The writer is Professor (Marketing), IMT Ghaziabad

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

June 12, 2006

RBI norms force banks to keep off venture funds

The high-return venture capital fund investment business is now virtually off limits for banks following the Reserve Bank of India's recent guidelines. In the annual monetary policy in April 2006, the RBI included banks' investment in such funds as part of their total capital market exposure and as signed a higher risk weight of 150 per cent to such exposures.

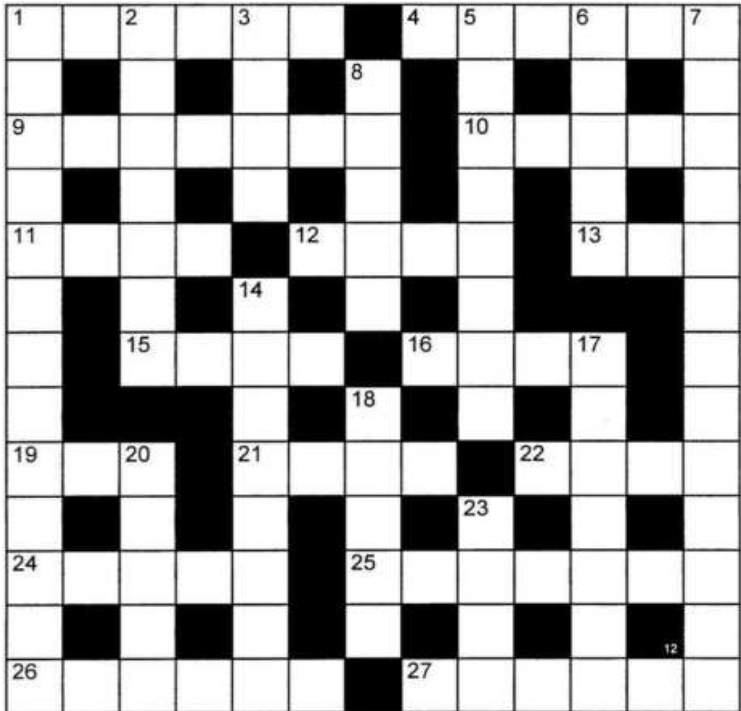
Reliance seeks to offer GSM services in Mumbai, Delhi

The Anil Ambani-promoted Reliance Communication has applied to the Department of Telecom seeking radio frequency to start cellular services based on GSM technology in Delhi and Mumbai.

Farmers dig up expressway

The agitation by a group of farmers, up in arms against Nandi Infrastructure Corridor Enterprise (NICE) for non-payment of "adequate compensation" for their land acquired for the Bangalore Mysore Infrastructure Corridor (BMIC) project and failure to erect a service road, entered the second day on Sunday. The farmers launched the protest on Saturday and dug up a portion of the road.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2670



EASY

ACROSS

01. Add drop by drop (6)
04. Correct, seemly (6)
09. Paper conferring honour (7)
10. Abdominal pain (5)
11. Prepare food (4)
12. Be unsuccessful (4)
13. Jump one-footed (3)
15. Minute (4)
16. Second-hand (4)
19. To arrest, pinch (3)
21. Part of tooth embedded in gum (4)
22. Grain-store (4)
24. Shinbone (5)
25. Female melodist of verse (7)
26. Sweet, melodious (6)
27. Population count (6)

DOWN

01. Initiated into the mysteries (13)
02. Prop (7)
03. Metal club (4)
05. Rash, heedless of consequences (8)
06. Cloth for wrapping baby (5)
07. They receive hotel guests (13)
08. Man-made waterway (5)
14. Get larger in number (8)
17. Undergarment for nether regions (7)
18. In washing, unrinsed (5)
20. Scene of confusion; confusion of many voices (5)
23. Give way, yield to another (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

01. Slowly feed the mind with its nil outcome (6)
04. The appropriate professional for each (6)
09. Document an embassy official didn't finish (7)
10. Pain in the gut to cool with nothing less than endless ice (5)
11. Prepare course for an explorer (4)
12. If a learner driver is weaving about, don't pass him (4)
13. Dance on which one doesn't expect to be caught (3)
15. Very small return it makes to New York (4)
16. Regularly took drugs, being experienced (4)
19. Pinch Prohibition back (3)
21. Mathematical function of a radical (4)
22. Storage place where one can drink nectar first (4)
24. A bit one included in backbone separately (5)
25. As a writer she'd make it brighter (7)
26. How sweet-toned Elsie sounds in a piece for two (6)
27. It counts the inhabitants with cues which might include poles (6)

DOWN

01. Instructed in the principles of direction – and about time! (13)
02. Back-up of kind pup may be involved in (7)
03. An element, as found in laundry utensil (4)
05. Like a daredevil not to matter so much (8)
06. Infant's wrap to clip up with brooch finally (5)
07. They greet guests or inspect ties put out for them (13)
08. Waterway in American alluvial system (5)
14. Get more cranes, maybe: that's about it (8)
17. Artists' knickers? (7)
18. Perhaps pays to include nothing with suds (5)
20. Scene of confusion with infant starting lunch (5)
23. Give way to some precedence (4)

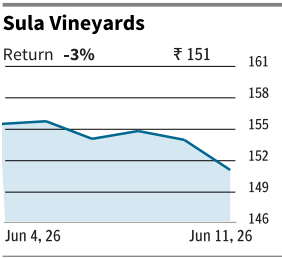
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2699

ACROSS 1. Flattery 7. Court 8. Compete 9. Knocked 10. Link 12 Dwindle 14. Schemer 17. Acre 18. Cabaret 21. Trapped 22. Nerve 23. Reprieve

DOWN 1. Facile 2. Admonish 3. Teen 4. Reeked 5. Tuck 6. Stodge 7. Crowning 11. Immerse 13. Disciple 14. Second 15. Rattle 16. Peddle 19. Burn 20. Pair

QUICKLY.

Sula Vineyards promoter share rises to 24.6%



Mumbai: Promoter shareholding in Sula Vineyards has increased to 24.6 per cent following a series of open market purchases by Founder and CEO Rajeev Samant, the company said in a regulatory filing. Samant acquired 60,000 shares of the company in June 2026 through open market transactions. He has cumulatively purchased around 2.3 lakh shares, taking the promoter group's stake in the company to 24.6 per cent from 24.3 per cent as of December 31, 2025. This represents the first increase in promoter shareholding since the company's listing in December 2022, the company added.

Samco Securities floats entity for global investing

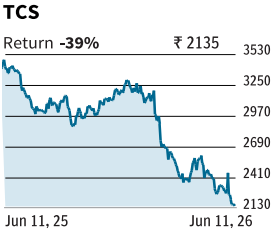
Mumbai: Samco Securities has launched a global investing platform after securing a broker-dealer licence from the International Financial Services Centres Authority at GIFT City. The platform allows Indian investors to invest in US-listed stocks and ETFs under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme, with fractional ownership starting at \$1 and access to research on over 700 securities. The platform integrates quantitative research, recommendations, targets, stop-loss frameworks and portfolio monitoring, aiming to make global investing more accessible for retail investors, it said.

Sensex, Nifty turn volatile as defence, IT stocks sell-off weighs on sentiment

CAUTIOUS TONES. Citi, PL Capital cut Nifty target amid valuation, geopolitical tensions, FII selling concerns

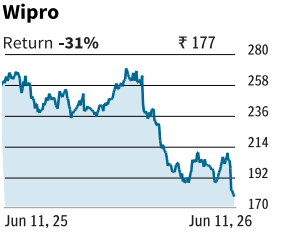
Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Benchmarks ended on a subdued note on Thursday, erasing intra-day gains, as renewed military exchanges between the US and Iran reignited concerns over the durability of the fragile ceasefire, keeping investor sentiment cautious. Unabated weakness in IT stocks led the decline while defence stocks too come under renewed pressure. Meanwhile, global investment advisory firm Citi and domestic broker PL Capital cut their Nifty targets citing near-term multiple headwinds. The BSE Sensex fell 150.63 points to close at 73,832.55, while the Nifty 50 declined 53.35 points to

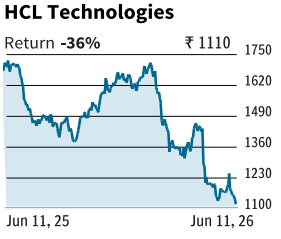


23,161.60. The broader market remained under pressure, with both mid-cap and small-cap indices ending lower.

CITI NIFTY TARGET
Citi has lowered Nifty target to 26,000 from 27,000 and its valuation multiple to 18 times from 19 times earlier. Geopolitical uncertainties, concerns around artificial intelligence and El Nino-related risks are weighing on



foreign institutional investor sentiment towards India. It also flagged the sustainability of strong consumer demand trends seen in the March quarter as a key near-term concern. According to Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments, markets witnessed a brief recovery during the session amid easing crude oil prices, but the gains proved short-lived.



He added that IT stocks remained under pressure amid concerns that stronger US inflation could delay interest rate cuts and keep global liquidity tight. Most sectoral indices ended in negative territory, with defence and IT stocks witnessing the sharpest declines. Media emerged as the top-performing sector, while pharma and private banks posted modest gains. The weakness in techno-

Vedanta demerged entities to trade from June 15

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The four newly carved-out companies — Vedanta Aluminium, Vedanta Power, Vedanta Oil & Gas and Vedanta Iron & Steel — from Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta will be listed for trading on the BSE and NSE from June 15. The stocks will be in trade-for-trade segment for 10 trading days. The parent company, Vedanta Ltd, will also remain listed, operating primarily as a base metals company representing Hindustan Zinc and Copper. The demerger officially



became effective on May 1. Eligible shareholders have received one equity share in each of the four newly listed businesses for every one Vedanta share. The record to identify eligible shareholders was fixed as May 1.

Prime Securities launches real estate AIF

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Prime Securities said its group company, Prime Litmus Investment Management, has entered the alternative investment fund (AIF) business with the launch of the Prime Litmus Real Estate Opportunities Fund, targeting ₹1,000 crore, including a greenshoe option. The Category II AIF has a base size of ₹750 crore and a greenshoe option of ₹250 crore and will focus on structured credit investments in under-construction real estate projects across major markets.

SEBI proposes uniform price-band mechanism for illiquid stocks listed on multiple exchanges

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Thursday proposed a uniform mechanism for determining price bands and pre-open session base prices for stocks listed on multiple exchanges, to resolve instances of significant price divergence in illiquid securities. The regulator has proposed that where a stock trades on only one exchange on a given day, the other exchange should use the closing price of the exchange where trading occurred to determine the next day's

price band and the base price for the pre-open call auction session. Further, where a stock trades on two or more exchanges but remains inactive on one or more exchanges, the non-trading exchange would use the closing price of the exchange that recorded the highest trading volume in that stock for determining the subsequent day's price band and pre-open base price.

PRICE ALIGNMENT
Currently, stock exchanges apply stock-specific price bands, up to 20 per cent on either side of the previous closing price for stocks that are not traded in the derivat-



ives segment. Some stocks witness trading on one exchange but not on another for several days, leading to widening differences in closing prices because exchanges apply price bands based on their own previous-day closing prices. This has been observed particularly in illiquid scrips

ing Tesla Inc, with the cohort owning about 40 per cent of the company's shares, according to BNP Paribas analyst James Picariello's estimates. SpaceX has received orders from about 1,000 institutional investors, some of the people said.

OFFERING TERMS
The terms of the offering such as the \$135 per share price and the 555.6 million shares are unlikely to change, some of the people said. SpaceX is set to allocate less than 10 per cent of the shares in its IPO to international orders, some of the people said. Japan's allocation was increased earlier this month to \$2.5 billion from \$2 billion.

Banks were expected to stop taking orders for SpaceX's IPO from institutional investors on Wednesday, ahead of pricing later on Thursday and trading on Friday.

Large and mid-cap category funds attract steady flows

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Large and mid-cap funds are registering a steady inflows mainly by investors who are bullish on both large and mid-cap funds due to beaten down valuations after the recent market meltdown on the back of lingering West Asia war. The large and mid-cap category has received an inflow of ₹3,278 crore last month higher than ₹1,593 crore of large-cap funds. However, mid-cap received investment of ₹4,385 crore in May. Similarly, in April large and mid-cap funds attracted an investment of ₹4,490 crore while stand-alone large and mid-cap funds received inflow of ₹2,525 crore and ₹6,551 crore respectively. The present lows in the large and mid-cap was largely due to conflict and global uncertainty.



The fall is not due to the fundamentals of the companies.

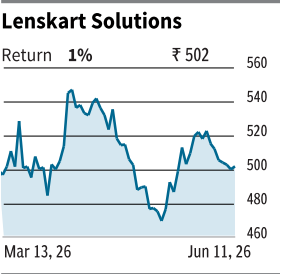
BUYING STRATEGY
Pankaj Mathpal, Founder, Optima Money, said buying at these levels is an opportunity and investing in mutual funds with a portfolio in large and mid-cap companies is a good strategy. This perhaps is the perfect time to enter the market, especially for mutual fund investors, who missed the bus earlier, before the bulls took over, he said. The recent decline in equities has narrowed India's valuation premium, re-

moved the excessive hike in equity prices and have positioned large and mid-cap companies at more comfortable levels. Large and mid-cap mutual funds have been performing well over the last few years. Nippon India Vision Large and Midcap Fund, which is one of the oldest funds in the category has delivered three-year annualised return of 18 per cent. ICICI gave a return of 16 per cent, while large and multi-cap funds from Bandhan MF and Invesco MF have clocked in returns of 15 per cent and 15 per cent in the last three years. Mutual fund advisors bet big on large and mid-cap mutual funds since large caps provide strength and mid-caps have a huge growth potential. Investing in current uncertain times can give alpha returns, provided investors do not panic in case of a further fall in the markets and stay invested.

Lenskart: GS, Morgan Stanley, others buy 2.3% stake from ADIA

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Global financial institutions, including Goldman Sachs, Morgan Stanley and Societe Generale, on Thursday collectively bought a 2.3 per cent stake in eyewear firm Lenskart Solutions from the Abu Dhabi Investment Authority for ₹1,960 crore through open market transactions. Following the purchase, shares of Lenskart Solutions rose 0.37 per cent to close at ₹502 apiece on the NSE.



Among domestic institutional investors, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund (MF), Kotak Mahindra MF, Mirae Asset MF, SBI MF, Canara Robeco MF, Franklin Templeton MF, Aditya Birla Sun Life MF, and Mumbai-based Alpha Alternatives Holdings also bought shares of Lenskart. Insurance firms, including ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company, Kotak Mahindra Life Insurance, HDFC Life Insurance and National Pension System (NPS) Trust, also partici-

ated in the transaction, according to the block deal data available on the NSE. The investors collectively purchased a total of 4 crore, amounting to a 2.3 per cent stake in Lenskart Solutions. The shares were picked up at an average price of ₹490. Meanwhile, Platinum Jasmine A 2018 Trust offloaded the same number of shares in Peyush Bansal-led eyewear retailer. Sovereign wealth fund Abu Dhabi Investment Authority (ADIA) is the sole beneficiary and settlor of the Platinum Jasmine A 2018 Trust. After the latest transaction, ADIA's holding in Lenskart dropped to 9.78 per cent from 12.08 per cent. Last week, technology investor SoftBank Group divested a 3.25 per cent stake in Lenskart Solutions for ₹2,873 crore. SoftBank was one of Lenskart's largest shareholders before the company went public.

BROKER'S CALL.

Macquarie

ADANI POWER (NEUTRAL)
Target: ₹230
CMP: ₹215.65
Macquarie has initiated coverage on Adani Power with a target price of ₹230/sh (15x 2 year forward EV/EBITDA) India's power demand outlook remains structurally robust despite a recent slowdown in growth, with underlying fundamentals supported by diverse, non-cyclical drivers. Demand is increasingly anchored by an expanding industrial base, rising 24x7 commercial loads from data centres and a sharp, non-linear increase in residential cooling demand. Recent peak demand of about 271 GW in May, driven by an intense heatwave, highlights tightening supply-demand dynamics, with minimal operating headroom and even marginal deficits during solar hours, underscoring sustained system stress amid structurally rising demand. India's power value chain stands on a structurally sound footing, driven by a synchronised turnaround across generation, transmission and distribution. In generation, capacity addition is happening at about 50 GW/year, spearheaded by renewables. In transmission, networks are undergoing a record capex cycle as part of a broader ₹9-lakh crore long-term grid expansion plan. Most critically, long-standing discom financial health has fundamentally turned the corner; distribution companies achieved a historic, positive all-India net profit of about ₹2,700 crore, as AT&C losses compressed to about 15 per cent (versus about 23 per cent in FY14) and strict late payment surcharge rules successfully liquidated nearly 96 per cent of legacy generation dues by early 2026.

Anand Rathi Research

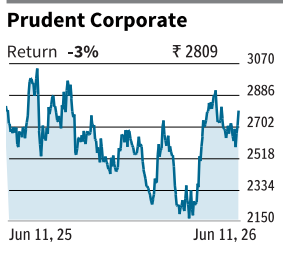
LUMAX AUTO TECH (BUY)
Target: ₹2,150
CMP: ₹1,604.45
For Q4 FY26, Lumax Auto Technologies reported robust quarterly revenue at ₹1,417 crore, 25 per cent year-on-year increase, reflecting sustained growth across key product segments, continued business momentum with OEMs and strong performance in the aftermarket portfolio. PAT grew 22 per cent in Q4FY26 to ₹98 crore, supported by continued focus on strengthening its standalone portfolio and improved utilisation of operational assets. Lumax has a healthy order-book of around ₹1,450 crore, giving it strong revenue visibility for the next three years. The company expects to execute about 25 per cent of these orders in FY27, 54 per cent in FY28, and the remaining 21 per cent in FY29. Capex for FY27 is expected to be about ₹275-300 crore to support capacity expansion and new models. Despite near-term geopolitical uncertainties and macroeconomic challenges, the company reiterated its medium-term revenue growth target of about 20 per cent CAGR through FY31. Demand momentum remains healthy entering Q1FY27, although margins may face temporary pressure from elevated raw material and energy costs. The company expects to continue outperforming industry growth, with select businesses growing at 2-3x the industry rate, driven by value-added products and increasing wallet share with key customers. Therefore, we continue to recommend with Buy rating for the stock with an unchanged target price of ₹2,150.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Prudent Corporate Advisory (₹2,809.25): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for Prudent Corporate Advisory Services. The 3.5 per cent rise on Thursday indicates that the stock has begun a new leg of an upmove. The rise is happening after forming a strong base above ₹2,600. This, coupled with the moving average crossovers on the daily chart, strengthens the bullish case. It also signals that the downside could be limited. Support is now in the ₹2,730-₹2,710 range. Prudent Corporate Advisory Services' share price can rise to ₹3,050-₹3,100 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy the stock now at ₹2,809. ccumulate

on dips at ₹2,760. Keep the stop-loss at ₹2,670 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹2,840 when the price goes up to ₹2,875. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹2,880 and ₹2,960 when the share price touches ₹2,910 and ₹2,990, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹3,050. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23228

» Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23100	22980	23360	23440	Go short on a break below 23100 with a stop-loss at 23140

₹745

» HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
743	736	749	754	Go long now and at 744. Keep the stop-loss at 742

₹1119

» Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1105	1085	1135	1150	Take fresh shorts below 1105. Keep the stop-loss at 1110

₹283

» ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
280	278	287	290	Go long on dips at 281. Stop-loss can be kept at 279

₹252

» ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
250	246	256	262	Go short only below 250. Stop-loss can be placed at 251

₹1265

» Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1250	1225	1270	1290	Go long on a bounce from 1250 with a stop-loss at 1245

₹1000

» SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
988	980	1015	1030	Take fresh longs above 1015. Keep the stop-loss at 1010

₹2137

» TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2110	2080	2150	2210	Go long on a break above 2150. Keep the stop-loss at 2140

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 53.35 pts.
	Close(t)	Pts	PE	WN(t)	
ICICI Bank	1317.00	37.00	16.27	8.88	
M&M	3000.90	9.44	20.04	2.53	
Kotak Bank	393.35	8.44	20.28	2.73	
Reliance Ind	1253.90	6.19	17.85	6.04	
Bharti Airtel	1782.60	4.96	32.11	5.16	
JSW Steel	1282.30	2.56	12.29	1.13	
Sun Pharma	1794.20	1.80	37.41	1.79	
Axis Bank	1317.30	1.75	15.42	3.56	
Grasim Ind	3089.50	1.52	20.41	1.11	
Cipla	1383.30	0.77	28.94	0.73	
Maruti Suzuki	13998.00	0.72	28.05	1.62	
ONGC	252.60	0.59	6.38	0.93	
Dr Reddys Lab	1276.00	0.57	25.62	0.73	
NTPC	351.85	0.21	12.39	1.57	
Apollo Hosp	8493.00	0.10	60.98	0.82	
TataConsumerProduct	1108.60	0.09	70.92	0.68	
Max Healthcare	1099.60	-0.08	68.11	0.71	
PowerGrid Corp	286.65	-0.54	16.74	1.22	
Bajaj Auto	10114.00	-0.73	26.73	1.06	
UltraTech Cement	10830.00	-0.93	38.97	1.21	
SBI Life	1719.10	-0.94	69.80	0.73	
Wipro	1717.37	-0.97	14.02	0.48	
HDFC Life	5455.25	-1.07	61.52	0.55	
Engelohweli	4502.40	-1.11	0.00	0.96	
Glitcher Motors	7179.50	-1.20	35.71	0.93	
Adani Enter	2908.80	-1.40	37.76	0.79	
Titan	4025.20	-1.52	70.43	1.57	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	228.02	-1.54	92.81	0.71	
Tech Mahindra	1465.10	-1.91	29.87	0.88	
State Bank	1090.70	-2.31	10.66	3.92	
Tata Motors PV	375.90	-2.33	4614.33	0.74	
Coal India	446.20	-2.38	8.85	0.96	
Asian Paints	2690.90	-2.39	58.73	1.15	
Bajaj Finserv	1645.10	-2.41	13.39	0.90	
Tata Steel	197.96	-2.44	22.70	1.54	
Westelndia	1462.50	-2.47	78.26	0.96	
ITC	282.40	-2.63	16.83	2.57	
Trent Ltd.	2710.90	-3.18	83.98	0.85	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	886.25	-3.39	20.80	1.17	
TCS	2135.60	-4.08	15.62	2.06	
Bharat Elec	402.30	-4.73	48.51	1.36	
Hindalco	1024.54	-4.74	17.19	1.40	
HCL Tech	1110.20	-5.05	18.09	1.10	
Adani Ports	1787.10	-5.49	32.21	1.24	
Hind Unilever	2139.80	-5.76	47.51	1.79	
Eternal Ltd.	235.20	-7.24	620.15	1.60	
HDFC Bank	744.60	-7.52	14.47	10.70	
Bajaj Finance	870.55	-7.92	28.02	2.24	
L&T	3862.00	-14.23	28.54	4.28	
Infosys	1114.60	-23.51	15.34	3.68	

Pfs: Impact on index movement				
Nifty Next 50 Movers				
	Close(t)	Pts	PE	WN(t)
Torrent Pharma	4572.20	32.07	72.38	1.98
Vedanta	304.90	26.89	7.52	2.14
Hyundai Motor India .	1940.10	19.78	29.02	1.14
Divis Lab	6555.50	6.11	68.80	3.50
ZydusLifesciences	1105.90	5.37	21.72	1.14
MacroTech Developers .	868.05	4.81	25.27	1.01
Jindal Steel	1121.30	0.21	34.03	0.72
Tata Capital	321.35	0.06	27.89	0.57
DH	563.00	-0.36	31.57	1.49
United Spirits	1257.94	-1.75	49.00	1.54
MuthootFin	2890.00	-2.67	10.94	1.28
Siemens Energy India .	3412.50	-3.07	92.78	1.25
Hindus Zinc	545.00	-3.12	16.65	0.98
Mazgaon Dock	2347.50	-4.32	34.36	0.74
Bosch	37565.00	-5.51	39.95	1.35
Shree Cement	23700.00	-5.67	48.90	1.31
Ambuja Cements	406.05	-6.46	18.26	1.92
Pidilith	1498.80	-6.75	61.74	1.92
Indian Railway Finance Corp	93.33	-8.36	17.40	0.78
Bank Of Baroda	267.60	-8.91	6.90	2.05
Bpcl	286.35	-9.45	4.81	2.40
Punjab Natl Bank	106.17	-9.74	6.61	1.51
Union Bank	1024.54	-10.43	6.46	1.83
Abb India	6719.00	-12.15	90.11	1.46
Cg Power & Ind Sol	901.35	-13.09	118.62	2.56
Gall (India)	166.09	-14.64	14.40	1.85
Siemens	3522.00	-15.16	81.83	1.29
Saavnvmothersoninternat	140.74	-18.39	36.36	2.57
Canara Bank	131.52	-18.48	6.67	1.83
Britannia Ind	5113.00	-19.23	48.54	2.49
Cummins India	5557.00	-20.04	65.22	3.10
Ratna	900.00	-21.04	11.21	1.11
Godrej Consumer	1009.08	-21.26	58.85	2.27
Tata Power	390.25	-21.29	24.37	2.70
Cholamandalam&Fin	1454.90	-21.42	23.69	2.58
Varunsuper	3987.00	-23.47	87.36	2.43
Venus Beverages .	513.90	-24.56	54.79	2.94
HindustanAeronaotics	412.00	-25.15	20.82	2.01
Indian Hotels Co.	655.70	-25.19	41.53	2.38
AdaniEnergygreeny	1454.50	-27.00	120.57	3.02
IndianOilcorp	134.24	-27.87	4.34	2.07
Limtindree	3824.90	-31.26	22.76	1.47
Tco Motor Corp .	3287.40	-31.52	49.01	3.19
Reliance	900.00	-33.29	38.95	2.01
Solar Industries	17141.00	-38.28	89.32	1.73
Tata Motors Cv	358.35	-38.69	43.58	3.10
Rural Elec	338.85	-42.18	5.44	1.74
Adani Power .	2151.51	-59.26	32.04	3.68
Adani Energy Solutions .	477.55	-73.64	4.06	2.49
Power Finance	413.55	-73.94	4.06	2.49
Pfs: Impact on index movement				

QUICKLY.

IOB hikes rates for select non-callable FDs



Chennai: Indian Overseas Bank (IOB), a public sector bank, has announced an upward revision in interest rates for its domestic non-callable fixed deposits. The decision was finalised during the bank's recent Asset-Liability Committee (ALCO) meeting to align with changing market conditions. Following the ALCO directive, the bank has implemented a 10 basis points (0.10 per cent) interest rate hike across three specific time frames. Regular fixed deposits, NRO accounts, and NRE term deposits remain unchanged. The new rates offer better yields across select medium-term tenures, including the popular 444-day period, and will come into effect immediately from June 11, 2026. **OUR BUREAU**

Banks, India Inc flock to CDs, CPs due to easing short-term rates

RATE SOFTENING. Borrowers favour short-term funding amid uncertainty over interest rate outlook

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

There is no let-up in demand for short-term funds of up to one-year tenor from banks and India Inc despite external headwinds arising from the West Asia conflict, as interest rates at the shorter end of the yield curve have softened.

Fundraising through Certificates of Deposit (CDs) by banks and Commercial Papers (CPs) by corporates, primary dealers and all-India financial institutions in the current financial year has remained robust and compares favourably with the year-ago period, even as bank credit growth continues to outpace deposit growth.

In FY27 so far (up to June 8, 2026), banks collectively raised ₹2.18 lakh crore through 190 CD issuances, compared with ₹2.55 lakh crore mobilised through 249



FRESH MEASURES. RBI's recent measures aimed at attracting foreign currency inflows have softened money market rates

issuances during the first quarter (April-June) of FY26, according to data from primary capital market information provider Prime Database.

Similarly, India Inc raised ₹3.6 lakh crore through 1,712 CP issuances during the period, against ₹4.51 lakh crore through 2,166 issuances in the first quarter of FY26. According to the latest RBI data, incremental credit growth of scheduled commercial banks stood at 17.44 per cent as of May 31, 2026,

exceeding incremental deposit growth of 12.14 per cent by 530 basis points.

BORROWING PULL

Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder and Managing Partner of Rockfort Fincap LLP, said the current softness in money market rates has made short-term borrowing increasingly attractive. As a result, fundraising through CDs and CPs could scale fresh highs during the current fiscal.

However, he cautioned

that excessive dependence on short-term instruments and repeated rollovers could create asset-liability mismatches and refinancing risks, particularly for borrowers funding long-tenor assets.

A balanced funding strategy, therefore, remains critical.

Srinivasan noted that CP and CD rates have witnessed significant volatility during FY27. Rates initially moved higher as markets reacted to escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

However, following the RBI's recent measures aimed at attracting foreign currency inflows and supporting the rupee, money market rates have softened considerably.

Between May 26 and June 10, 2026, rates on 2-3 month bank CDs declined to around 6.85-6.90 per cent from 7.48-7.52 per cent, while 12-month CD rates eased to

about 7.55 per cent from 7.98 per cent. Similarly, rates on 2-3 month CPs issued by A1+ rated public sector and manufacturing companies softened to around 6.92-6.93 per cent from 7.50-7.54 per cent. CP rates for housing finance companies eased to about 6.95 per cent from 7.60-7.64 per cent.

Even NBFC CP rates declined sharply, with 2-3 month borrowing costs falling to 7.35-7.50 per cent from 7.95-8.15 per cent.

According to Srinivasan, the decline in rates reflects improved market confidence and expectations of better liquidity conditions stemming from inflows linked to FCNR (B) deposits, external commercial borrowings (ECBs) and overseas foreign currency borrowings.

Nevertheless, uncertainty over the medium-term interest-rate outlook persists amid geopolitical tensions, and inflationary pressures.

India requires more than 200 satellites in 3 years: ISRO chief

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



ISRO Chairman V Narayanan

India will need to launch over 200 satellites in the next three years to meet growing national and commercial requirements, Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) Chairman V Narayanan said on Thursday, calling for deeper participation from private industry, start-ups and academia in the space sector.

“Currently, we have 56 satellites in orbit. But we require 200-plus satellites in another three years for the country. ISRO alone cannot do this. The entire space ecosystem has to work towards that. Lot of opportunities are there,” Narayanan said at the 10th Industry Connect event organised by IN-SPaCe in Ahmedabad.

He said ISRO is increasingly positioning itself as an enabler for the broader ecosystem rather than working in isolation.

SECTORAL REFORMS

Narayanan noted that India's space start-up ecosystem has expanded significantly following sectoral reforms, with more than 400 start-ups now operating in the domain. He stressed that future growth will depend on co-ordinated efforts across ISRO, industry and research institutions.

Highlighting long-term ambitions, the ISRO chief said India is also moving ahead with plans for an indigenous space station.

“We are also building our own space station. You can see the model. It is a 52-

tonne space station. India will have its own space station by 2035,” he said.

Narayanan also outlined the evolution of India's space programme — from early sounding rocket experiments to complex deep-space and commercial missions.

MAJOR MILESTONES

On commercial capabilities, he said India has transitioned into a global launch hub, including missions carrying large foreign payloads.

“From that humble beginning, India progressed to a purely commercial launch of a 6,000 kg satellite for an American company using an Indian rocket,” he said.

He added that India has conducted over 4,000 sounding rocket launches, while its satellite fleet has expanded from early experimental systems to advanced platforms.

Meanwhile, on Thursday, IN-SPaCe signed a deal with the government of Tamil Nadu to develop a common technical facility at the upcoming Space Vehicles Cluster at SIPCOT Allikulam, which is being set up with a focus on ‘manufacturing, testing and integration of launch vehicle systems’.

Banks raise MCLR amid tightening funding costs

Maresh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

Public sector lenders have begun raising their marginal cost of funds-based lending rates (MCLR), signalling a tightening in funding conditions, with Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda, Union Bank, Bank of India and Central Bank of India announcing increases across select tenures.

On Thursday, Union Bank raised its MCLR by 5 basis points (bps) across tenures. Union Bank raised MCLR for overnight to three-years tenure by 5 bps from 7.85 per cent to 9.05 per cent. Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda and bank of India also announced a 5 bps increase in MCLR across select tenures.

Canara Bank raised MCLR for overnight to six-month tenures by 5 bps, while leaving longer-tenure rates un-

changed. Its revised MCLR now ranges from 7.95 per cent to 9.05 per cent. Bank of Baroda, in contrast, increased MCLR by 5 bps across all tenures, taking its range to 7.85-8.75 per cent.

MARGINAL COSTS

Private sector lender HDFC Bank also hiked MCLR by up to 10 bps across select tenors, taking its overall rates range from 8.05 per cent to 8.65 per cent, reflecting sim-

The adjustments come even as the RBI has kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25%

ilar pressures on funding costs across the banking system. The adjustments come even as the Reserve Bank of India has kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent after cumulative cuts last

year, indicating that liquidity conditions rather than policy rates are driving lending benchmarks.

“Increases in MCLR reflect the ongoing tightness in system liquidity and rising marginal cost of funds for banks. With deposit mobilisation becoming more competitive, lenders are gradually transmitting these higher costs to borrowers. While this trend is likely to persist in the near term,

much will depend on the evolution of liquidity conditions and the pace of deposit growth,” said Sanjay Agarwal, Senior Director, CareEdge Ratings.

Gaura Sengupta, Chief Economist, IDFC First Bank, said, “This should ease by July-August once the FCNR (B) money start coming.”

A rise in MCLR leads to higher borrowing costs for corporate and retail loans linked to this benchmark.

More opportunities for industry to access foreign markets under Modi-led govt: Maruti's Bhargava

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL) Chairman RC Bhargava on Thursday hailed the Narendra Modi-led government's economic and industrial policies, asserting that the company's annual vehicle exports had increased from about one lakh units in 2013-14 to around 4.5 lakh units in 2025-26.

In a post on X, Bhargava said that these 12 years have been “transformational for industry”, and equally remarkable has been the Prime Minister's ability to build trust and confidence among foreign countries with India.

“The result has been more opportunities for Indian in-

dustry to access foreign markets and increase bilateral trade. The close link between industrial growth, competitiveness and the growth of employment and wealth in the country was first recognised, and measures taken to remove past obstacles, after Modi became the Prime Minister in 2014,” he said.

The Maruti Chairman said the PM placed great importance on rural development and the welfare of the weaker sections. Digital technology enabled the direct transfer of benefits to the intended recipients, with no middlemen, he said.

RURAL SALES

“Schemes helped the poor to construct houses, gain access to clean water, and send



RC Bhargava, Chairman, Maruti Suzuki India

girls to schools. Farmers received substantial support. The result was growing rural prosperity. The share of MSIL cars sold in rural areas increased from 32 per cent to 52 per cent, a truly remarkable transformation resulting from government policies,” Bhargava said.

Various steps to make it

easier to do business, remove legal impediments in the way of growth, reform the tax structure and bring about rapid growth in the use of digital technology were actions that led to elimination of wasteful costs, saved time, and increased competitiveness of Indian goods, Bhargava said.

“The infrastructure programme was sharply intensified, helping to reduce logistic costs. India is increasingly becoming a preferred destination for supply chains moving out of China,” he noted.

Bhargava added that India is now the third largest car manufacturing country in the world and significant employment is created when cars are sold and used.

Policy uniformity, public trust vital for ethanol blending success

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad



Bharati Balaji, Deputy Director General, AIDA

To ensure that the Ethanol Blending Programme succeeds, the government must standardise state-level taxes and educate consumers to resolve lingering doubts about the fuel.

To accelerate its Ethanol Blending Programme (EBP) by granting complete excise duty exemptions on higher ethanol-blended petrol variants — specifically targeting E22, E25, E27, and E30 blends — the Centre is establishing a financial and technical framework designed to curb India's reliance on expensive crude oil imports. However, this may not be enough.

STATE TAX ALIGNMENT

Bharati Balaji, Deputy Director General of the All India Distillers' Association (AIDA), told *businessline* that excise exemptions provide a vital commercial route for surplus ethanol capacity, which currently exceeds E-20 programme requirements. AIDA is urging State governments to align tax structures to ensure benefits reach consumers, while actively collaborating with the

Ministries of Petroleum & Natural Gas, Road Transport, and Food to address concerns regarding reduced fuel efficiency, she said.

“Consumer awareness is a vital pillar for the long-term success of India's ethanol blending programme. Historically, introducing new products to the Indian market triggers immediate resistance, as seen when chemical manufacturers protested molasses procurement during the programme's initial rollout. These challenges are simply standard, temporary hurdles,” she said.

Balaji emphasised that consumer awareness is vital, noting that while ethanol's lower energy content might slightly reduce fuel mileage, the issue must be viewed through a broader lens.

She urged a focus on overall vehicle technology, efficiency, carbon emissions,

running costs, energy security, and environmental benefits.

“The minor mileage drop we are talking about applies to vehicles built before 2023,” she said, adding that “it is important to note that modern vehicles are designed and calibrated for E20. In fact, they are engineered to optimise performance, emissions, and fuel efficiency under higher ethanol blends.”

CAPACITY AND DEMAND

On feedstock, Balaji explained that AIDA members — comprising top grain, molasses, and integrated distilleries — control about 80 per cent of India's ethanol production.

Explaining the capacity metrics, Balaji noted that India's current installed ethanol capacity stands close to 2,000 crore litres.

With the EBP requiring 1,100 crore litres and alternative sectors — including potable alcohol, pharmaceuticals, and chemicals — consuming 334 crore litres, total demand reaches 1,434 crore litres.

This leaves the industry sitting on a notable surplus capacity of approximately 566 crore litres.

HDFC Life's claim settlement ratio at 99.7% in FY26

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

HDFC Life registered a claim settlement ratio of 99.7 per cent for individual death claims in FY26.

“Timely and hassle-free settlement of every genuine claim will continue to be our priority,” said Sameer Yogishwar, Chief Operating Officer, HDFC Life.

“We are continually enhancing our capabilities and using technology to create an easier, more seamless, and more effective claim settlement process,” he added.

DIGITAL CLAIMS

The company is leveraging digital workflows, automation, AI-led validation, and analytics to simplify claims processing. Claimants can now initiate and track claims digitally, upload documents online, and receive timely communication updates throughout the process. Digital claims journeys reduce dependency on physical visits and manual paperwork for the claimants. Under Project Inspire, HDFC Life is driving ZeroTouch Processing, FastTrack processes, and realtime payment enablement in the claims domain.

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM REGIONAL CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD.
Head Office: "Ksheera Bhavan", Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram - 695 004.
Phone: +91474-2447109, email: trcmppu@gmail.com
NO.174/TRU/P&T/MR/2026-27 Date: 12.06.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE
E-tenders are invited for the following item at TRCMPU:

E-Tender ID	Description	Approximate Tender Value
2026_KCMMF_851137_1	SUPPLY OF TOTAL MIXED RATION	Rs. 325 Lakhs

Specifications and details of the e-tender are available in the Government e-procurement portal (www.etenders.kerala.gov.in) and TRCMPU website (www.milmatrcmpu.com). Last date for submission of e-tender is on 22.06.2026, 01:00 PM.

Sd/- Managing Director

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding) in Mumbai.
1) OLA for Solution Premier services of Telephone exchange across Tata Power. (RFQ No. 4100066499)
2) OLA of Power connection infrastructure works for Maharashtra 1 years. (RFQ No. 4100065975)
3) OLA of Power connection infrastructure works for AP & Telangana 2 years. (RFQ No. 4100065972)
4) OLA of Power connection infrastructure works for Rajasthan 2 years. (RFQ No. 4100065971)
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Interested bidders to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter along with Complete Bid Document by 3rd July 2026, 05:00 PM.
Also, all future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tender will be informed on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

Malabar Regional Co-operative Milk Producers' Union Ltd.
Head Office, Peringalam, Kunnamanagalam, Kozhikode-673 571, Kerala
Website: www.malabarmilma.com, Email: mrmpu@malabarmilma.coop
Phone 0495-2805407, 420 428, Mobile No: 91681 80395

TENDER NOTICE
Tenders are invited from eligible bidders through e-procurement window of Government of Kerala (www.etenders.kerala.gov.in) for the following works.

Items	Closing date
SITC of Walk in Blast Tunnel Freezer at Kozhikode Dairy E-tender Id: 2026_KCMMF_855388_1	26.06.2026
SITC of Automatic Ghee Filling and Packaging Lines at various Dairies E-tender Id: 2026_KCMMF_855379_1	03.07.2026
Supply of 20 KLPH Milk chiller with accessories at various Dairies E-tender Id: 2026_KCMMF_855240_1	02.07.2026
Repair works of PUF Containers for various Dairies E-tender Id: 2026_KCMMF_855395_1	03.07.2026
SITC of 3KL BMC Tank for P&I Unit Kannur. E-tender Id: 2026_KCMMF_855375_1	22.06.2026

For further enquiries, visit our website or contact Head Office, MRCMPU Ltd, Managing Director

राष्ट्रीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान अगस्तला
NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY AGARTALA
Agartala, Tripura, India, Pin-799 046
Fax: 0381-2546360, Website: <http://www.nita.ac.in>

PNIT no. 23(166)/NITA/Estate/2016/Vo/II/1815 Dated: 08.06.2026
Press Notice Inviting e-Tender (PNIT)
On behalf of NIT Agartala, The Registrar NIT Agartala invite percentage/item rate e-tender from the eligible registered bidder for 03 (three) nos. Civil works upto 5:00 PM on 03.07.2026.
For details, please visit <http://www.nita.ac.in> & <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Date of opening of bid on 06.07.2026 at NIT Agartala upto 11:00 AM.
Any Subsequent corrigendum will be available in the above website only.
Registrar, NIT Agartala

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM REGIONAL CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD
Head Office: "Ksheera Bhavan", Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram - 695 004.
Phone: 0474-2447109, Fax: 2449567, email: trcmppu@gmail.com Website: www.milmatrcmpu.com.
TRU/PPM/12/2026-27 12.06.2026

RETENDER NOTICE
Tenders are invited for the following items at TRCMPU:

Sl. No.	Item	E - Tender ID	Approximate Tender Value (In Rs)
1	Supply of PET bottles	2026_KCMMF_852569_2	3,20,00,000

Specifications and details of the Tenders are available in E-tender portal (<https://etenders.kerala.gov.in>). Last date for submission of e-tender is on 23.06.2026, 02:00 PM. (The details are also available in the website - www.milmatrcmpu.com for reference).

MAITHON POWER LIMITED
(Contracts Department)
Maithon Power Ltd, Village: Dambhui, PO Barbindia, PIN-828205, District-Dhanbad

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
The Maithon Power Limited, a joint venture between Tata Power and DVC invites expression of interest from eligible vendors for the following packages:

S. No.	Ref. No	Package Description
1	2000092559	Corrigendum_NIT-2000092559 Overhauling of 216MVA GT and 25 MVA UAT

For details of pre-qualification requirements, bid security, purchasing of tender document etc., please visit our website URL- <https://www.tatapower.com/tender>
Eligible vendors willing to participate may submit their expression of interest along with the tender fee for issue of bid document latest by 19th June 26.

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station Sahar Airport Road, Andheri East, Mumbai-400059 (Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
The Tata Power Company Limited invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following package (Two Part Bidding) in Mumbai.
A) Outline Agreement (OLA) of 02 years for Construction of Transmission Tower Foundation (Pile) at Mumbai Operation region. (Package Ref No: CC275VP008)
Interested & eligible bidders for the above package to submit Tender Fee, Authorization Letter before 15:00 Hrs. Friday, 19th June 2026.
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website (Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents) only.

KERALA MARITIME BOARD
(A statutory Board of Govt. of Kerala)
TENDER NOTICE

Tender No: 02/2026-27/HOKMB-TVM/539/2025-C1(Devp)
Date: 10.06.2026
Tender for the Leasing out the Godown facility at Kovalam - Vizhinjam Port, Thiruvananthapuram Kerala Maritime Board (KMB), invites **Proposals** from competent and eligible parties who fulfill the eligibility criteria prescribed in the tender document for **Leasing out the Godown facility at Kovalam - Vizhinjam Port, Thiruvananthapuram in lease model.**
Bid form consisting of eligibility criteria, terms and conditions, and the Proforma of the tender can be downloaded from the e-tender portal of Kerala i.e, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in>.
The bid should be submitted through e-tender portal on or before 25.07.2026, 4 PM.
Sd/- Chief Executive Officer
D3/353/2026/I&PRD

QUICKLY.

NLC India inks MoU for critical mineral studies

Chennai: NLC India Ltd (NLCIL) has signed a memorandum of understanding with the CSIR-Central Electrochemical Research Institute, Karaikudi, to collaborate in the field of critical and strategic minerals beneficiation and extraction technologies. Under the MoU, detailed studies will be undertaken in NLCIL's Neyveli mines to assess the potential for extraction and recovery of rare earth elements and other trace elements. **OUR BUREAU**

India, Nepal launch cross-border remittance

New Delhi: India and Nepal have launched a peer-to-peer cross-border remittance mechanism on June 6, the Finance Ministry said. The new system establishes a direct link between the Unified Payments Interface and Nepal's National Payments Interface, enabling citizens of both nations to make real-time money transfers directly via mobile banking applications and digital wallets. **PTI**

Tax barrier holds back plug-in hybrid cars, pushing them into premium category

SEGMENT SHIFT. Tax differential of nearly ₹12 lakh has nudged PHEVs into the ₹40-50 lakh bracket

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



COSTLY DRIVE. Manufacturers are nevertheless building an India-focused PHEV pipeline almost entirely at the top end

India's plug-in hybrid vehicle (PHEV) market is finally taking shape, but its growth is being driven as much by tax policy as by consumer demand. On June 9, BYD showcased the Seal U DM-i for India, while Mercedes-Benz is set to launch the S 450e plug-in hybrid S-Class on June 15.

More brands, including JSW-backed ventures and MG Motor, are preparing long-range PHEV SUVs for FY27, positioning them as a bridge between petrol cars and battery electric vehicles (BEVs) for buyers concerned about charging infrastructure and long-distance travel.

That bridge, however, comes at a steep cost.

BEVs attract just 5 per cent GST, a concessional rate retained after the September 2025 GST 2.0 overhaul. Most PHEVs, by contrast, are taxed at 40 per cent. On a ₹35-lakh ex-factory vehicle,

that translates into roughly ₹14 lakh in GST for a PHEV versus about ₹1.75 lakh for a BEV — an effective tax gap of nearly ₹12 lakh.

The result is that many PHEVs that could have competed in the ₹25-30 lakh mass-premium segment are pushed into the ₹40-50 lakh bracket.

LUXURY BRIDGE

“Our DM-i technology is electric-first. For most daily driving, customers can run the vehicle like an EV, while the engine works mainly as a range extender for long-distance travel,” said Rajeev

Chauhan, Managing Director, BYD India.

The Seal U DM-i offers around 100 km of electric-only range and a combined range exceeding 1,000 km. Yet its expected ₹45-50 lakh price tag means it will compete with premium petrol SUVs rather than mainstream EVs, highlighting how taxation has turned PHEVs into a luxury technology.

THE GST WALL

The GST 2.0 reform removed the compensation cess previously levied on larger vehicles, simplifying tax-

ation and slightly lowering the burden. But the structural divide remains intact: 5 per cent GST for BEVs and 40 per cent for most PHEVs.

Nevertheless, BYD is expected to follow the Seal U DM-i with the Sealion 6 DM-i, while JSW Motors is preparing the Jetour T2 PHEV and JSW MG Motor is developing the MG Starlight 560 plug-in hybrid.

“PHEVs can play a practical transition role in markets where charging infrastructure is still evolving, but at current tax levels the economics work only for premium buyers,” said an industry executive involved in EV strategy discussions.

THE MISSING MIDDLE

Globally, PHEVs have often served as a bridge technology. India, however, has effectively created two extremes — heavily incentivised BEVs and heavily taxed hybrids, leaving little room for intermediate technologies.

There is a narrow excep-

tion. Under GST rules, a plug-in hybrid classified as a small car attracts 18 per cent GST instead of 40 per cent. But no major manufacturer is targeting that segment because most long-range PHEV architectures are designed around larger SUVs.

For consumers, the proposition remains attractive. A PHEV with about 100 km of electric range could cover most urban commuting on electricity while retaining petrol-powered flexibility for highway travel.

Policy-makers, however, continue to favour pure EVs as the preferred decarbonisation pathway.

“India skipped directly to incentivising pure EVs because policymakers wanted a decisive shift rather than a prolonged hybrid phase,” said an auto industry analyst. “The downside is that PHEVs are now too expensive to become a mass transition technology.”

For now, PHEVs remain largely an urban luxury proposition.



Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Founder, Biocon

India needs patient capital for biotech: Biocon founder

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, Executive Chairperson of Biocon Ltd, started the company in a Bengaluru garage in 1978 with ₹10,000, an idea few understood and a banking system that viewed her as a high-risk borrower.

Nearly five decades later, Biocon has grown into a global biopharmaceutical company with total income of ₹17,270 crore in FY26. Yet, Mazumdar-Shaw believes building the next Biocon could be even harder.

Speaking at the launch of the Rupa Rahul Bajaj Scholarship for Women in Engineering, the Biocon founder argued that India's biggest challenge in biotechnology is no longer talent or scientific capability but access to patient capital.

“We don't lack the talent. We don't lack the scientific capabilities. But we do lack the investment,” Mazumdar-Shaw said.

She warned that India risks losing ground in the global biotechnology race despite its scientific strengths. “When I started in the first decade of this century, we were way ahead of China. Today, China has almost overtaken the US when it comes to biotechnology,” she added.

The problem, she argued, lies in the country's funding architecture. “Our capital markets don't allow pre-revenue companies to list, whereas many other stock exchanges allow it,” she said.

THE CAPITAL GAP

Mazumdar-Shaw's argument is that India has built the front end of the innovation pipeline — research institutions, scientific talent and start-ups — but not the financial architecture needed to help those ideas scale into globally-competitive companies.

According to her, the absence of a public-market

pathway for pre-revenue science companies breaks the funding chain. Venture capital investors need a credible exit route, making them reluctant to back long-gestation innovation businesses that lack a pathway to public markets.

“Venture capitalists are not going to invest in these companies because they need an exit,” she said.

The result is a gap between research and commercialisation. While India is producing scientific talent and promising technologies, many companies struggle to attract the long-duration capital needed to scale.

“You need to create a virtuous cycle. Unless you do that and complete the circle, we will not be able to get anywhere close to China.”

The challenge, she argued, extends beyond biotechnology. Mazumdar-Shaw pointed to Electronics Corporation of India Ltd, which existed decades before Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co, yet failed to create a globally competitive ecosystem around it.

The lesson is that scientific capability alone is not enough. Countries that succeed in strategic sectors combine innovation with patient capital, supportive regulation and long-term industrial ecosystems.

India has already built much of the scientific talent and research base needed to compete globally. What remains unfinished, she argued, is the financial bridge that allows promising ideas to become globally-competitive businesses.

Opendoor India layoffs reignite debate over AI, future of offshore work

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

US real estate technology firm Opendoor's decision to shut its India operations and cut nearly 250 jobs has reignited concerns over AI-driven workforce disruption, with industry experts warning that routine, process-oriented roles are increasingly vulnerable as companies automate operations and reassess offshore delivery models.

Opendoor CEO Kaz Nejatian announced the move in a post on X, saying, “Our cus-

tomers are in America, and that's where our operational work belongs.” He also shared that the company is accelerating its AI-driven transformation.

Anuj Agrawal, Founder & CEO of Zyoin Group, highlighted that Opendoor's exit was forced by financial distress — revenue down 75 per cent from peak, losses of \$1.4 billion. Its real driver was a collapsed US housing market; AI removed the reason to keep those roles when the money ran out, he said.

“What made the India centre cuttable was how it was built — Operations As-

sociates, Transaction Coordinators, and Data Annotation Engineers, hired to bridge manual gaps between disconnected systems. That's what AI now does natively. Centres built on cost arbitrage are vulnerable,” Agrawal explained.

Amazon, Block, Cisco, Atlassian and Standard Chartered cut jobs in 2026 citing AI, with over 40,000 tech roles lost this year. However, AI has also become an explanation for plain financial distress.

Agrawal added that more cuts will come and AI will also shrink the size of off-

shore teams and raise the value of what they do.

Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital, expanded, observing that teams in India often handle process-driven and repetitive tasks — this is where AI is making the biggest impact.

LARGE TALENT POOL

“For years, India's advantage was its ability to provide large-scale talent at competitive costs.... This means demand may not grow at the same pace for large teams doing routine work. Instead, organisations will look for smaller, highly-skilled teams

that can build, manage, and improve AI-powered systems,” Sharma said.

India's opportunity lies in moving up the value chain and becoming a centre for innovation rather than just execution. AI reducing dependence on large teams performing repetitive and process-oriented work may also strengthen India's position. “Global organisations are expanding their investments in India because talent is available at scale... As AI automates routine work, companies will look for locations that can provide advanced skills, innovation

capability, and execution excellence,” said Ganesh S Padmanabhan, VP — Recruitment Business at CIEL HR.

UpGrad Rekrut's hiring data validates this, indicating that demand for AI roles such as prompt engineers, AI trainers, automation specialists, and data specialists is among the fastest-growing across its client base. “India's position in this flux is stronger than the anxiety suggests. The opportunity is to move up the value chain faster from execution to innovation, from process to intelligence,” said Husain Tinwala, CEO, upGrad Rekrut.

‘Global trade networks can help businesses navigate a fragmented world’

bl.interview

Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

With plans to expand to 50 World Trade Center licences in India over the next five to seven years, the World Trade Centers Association (WTCA) sees significant potential in the country. Scott Wang, Vice-President, Asia Pacific, discusses India's trade prospects, SME opportunities and the importance of global connectivity.

Edited excerpts:

Amid current global uncertainty and supply chain disruptions, how can organisations such as the WTCA help companies sustain market access and build resilience across regions?

At a time of uncertainty, companies need more help, especially when they are doing cross-border business. We think the best thing

against uncertainty is diversification.

This is exactly where we can help the business communities around the world. We have global connectivity that covers more than 300 major cities and trade hubs in around 100 countries and territories. This means we can help companies connect with local partners, regulators and businesses. We also have systems that facilitate this through our digital network and reciprocity desks.

A World Trade Center can send a request to another and get assistance. This has become a day-to-day part of our work across the global network, and I think the business community really appreciates that.

SMEs are among the most affected in such periods of uncertainty. How can WTCA help them access international markets in a practical and affordable way?

We talk a lot about something called a global trade



We have an objective to reach 50 World Trade Center licences in India over the next five to seven years

SCOTT WANG

VP, Asia Pacific, World Trade Centers Association



ecosystem. We have four major components. The first is branding — differentiation and publicity for the region, the business community and the World Trade Center project itself.

The second is hardware — the World Trade Center buildings and properties. In many cases, these are major premium office spaces and commercial complexes.

The third is global connectivity. These centres are not standalone; they are connected with the World Trade Center network around the world.

The fourth is our trade

service system, which has eight major components: trade information, trade education, business matchmaking, trade missions, conference facilities and services, exhibition facilities and services, business clubs and business services.

We work with local partners such as governments and industry associations to help small and medium-sized companies. For example, in Jaipur, where we have a World Trade Center, the jewellery industry has been affected by US tariffs. Most of these are small, family-run businesses.

They need help with market access and market education — understanding how to comply with new trade barriers, how to position themselves in an uncertain tariff environments, and how to market themselves through trade shows and expos hosted by the World Trade Center system and others.

India is signing a number of free trade agreements to offset global trade risks. Can WTCA help companies navigate these agreements and identify opportunities?

One advantage India has is its geopolitical position. It gets along with major trading blocs — the US, Europe and increasingly China as well.

But FTAs come with a lot of technicalities — compliance requirements, standards, market-access rules and thresholds. There is a lot we can do, and are already doing, to help SMEs leverage these agreements. I men-

tioned the Jaipur example earlier.

If companies do not have in-house expertise, we can provide consultancy services.

Many of these services can be delivered at low cost through partnerships with local government agencies.

Another major area is market access. At the end of the day, trade is about connecting buyers and sellers. Because we have local access through our World Trade Centers, we can help companies connect with the right partners, potential buyers and support services to make use of FTAs effectively.

How many World Trade Centers do you plan to establish in India over the next few years?

We have an objective to reach 50 World Trade Center licences in India over the next five to seven years. We are very confident we can achieve that based on the current pace and momentum.

Godrej bets ₹350 cr on material handling biz to tap q-comm boom

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The Godrej Enterprises Group is betting ₹350 crore on India's booming quick-commerce and warehousing sector as its ₹1,000 crore material handling business looks to scale to ₹1,500-2,000 crore over the next two years.

The plan is driven by rising demand for forklifts, warehouse automation and intra-logistics equipment from companies such as Blinkit, Zepto, Swiggy Instamart, Flipkart and Amazon, sources aware of the company's plans said.

Godrej has set up a facility at Khalapur, near Mumbai, with an initial capacity of 15,000 units annually, five times higher than the roughly 3,000-unit capacity at its Vikhroli plant — with

plans to eventually expand capacity to 30,000 units.

WAREHOUSE ECONOMY While consumers largely see delivery riders and mobile apps, executives say the real operational complexity lies inside warehouses and fulfilment centres where products are constantly sorted, stacked, lifted and replenished in real time to ensure rapid order fulfilment.

“It's very easy for us to imagine that 10-minute delivery — you just put it in the app and get it. But if you see the backend of how it happens, there is a huge supply chain continuously working,” Anil Lingayat, Business Head - Material Handling Equipment, Godrej Enterprises Group, told *businessline*.

According to Lingayat, the rapid expansion of quick-commerce platforms is cre-



Anil Lingayat, Business Head - Material Handling Equipment, Godrej Enterprises Group

ating a cascading warehouse infrastructure chain involving dark stores, fulfilment centres and large distribution hubs, each of which requires mechanised handling systems such as forklifts, reach trucks, stackers and pallet trucks.

Although e-commerce and quick-commerce currently account for around 8 per

cent of the division's business, the company expects the segment to become one of its fastest-growing demand drivers as online retail platforms expand deeper into tier-2 and -3 cities.

The company expects the material handling business to return to healthy double-digit growth this fiscal after two relatively slower years, supported by rising demand from quick commerce, organised retail, manufacturing and SMEs.

Industry experts say the rise of quick commerce is also sharply increasing SKU complexity inside warehouses, forcing operators to invest in more agile and automated material handling systems capable of handling a wider variety of products within tighter delivery windows.

The economics of quick commerce are also making

warehouse efficiency increasingly critical as platforms spend heavily on customer acquisition, discounts and faster fulfilment.

UNDER-PENETRATED

India's material handling market still remains relatively under-penetrated despite the country's rapidly expanding consumption economy.

According to company estimates, annual sales of powered material handling equipment in India stand at just 25,000-26,000 units, translating into an industry size of ₹4,000-4,500 crore. China, by comparison, is estimated to sell nearly 8 lakh such units annually.

Lingayat said India's warehousing ecosystem is now gradually formalising as organised retail, e-commerce, manufacturing and logistics networks expand.

NCLT admits insolvency pleas against Anil Ambani, RInfra arm

Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has admitted two significant insolvency petitions filed by public sector lenders — State Bank of India and Canara Bank — marking a fresh escalation in legal and financial challenges involving entities linked to Anil Ambani and RInfra.

The Mumbai Bench of the NCLT admitted State Bank of India's insolvency plea against Anil Ambani in his role as a personal guarantor for loans extended to Reliance Communications and Reliance Infratel, with dues of around ₹1,200 crore.

The loans, sanctioned in 2016, turned delinquent soon after, and despite in-



vocation of Ambani's personal guarantee, repayment has not been made.

PERSONAL GUARANTEE

Responding to the order, a spokesperson for Ambani said the matter relates to a disputed personal guarantee allegedly extended in 2016, prior to the enactment of personal insolvency provisions.

The spokesperson added that the underlying loans were used by Reliance Com-

munications to repay borrowings from Chinese lenders and that Ambani derived no personal benefit.

LEGAL FORUMS

The statement said the order will be reviewed and challenged before appropriate legal forums.

In a parallel development, the NCLT also admitted Canara Bank's plea to initiate insolvency proceedings against HK Toll Road Pvt Ltd, a wholly-owned subsidiary of RInfra, over unpaid dues of ₹283 crore.

The tribunal held that disputes raised by the company with the National Highways Authority of India over alleged wrongful termination of a highway concession cannot dilute its liability toward the lender.

QUICKLY.

Asus to manufacture gaming laptops in India

New Delhi: Taiwanese PC maker Asus plans to start production of gaming laptops in India in the ongoing financial year, said Paramjeet Singh Mehta, Head of Product and Marketing for Consumer Business at Asus India. “We are the first brand that will start making gaming laptops in India. We plan to localise 20-30 per cent of our total requirement in India,” he said. The company has partnered with an electronics manufacturing services company in Chennai for production, he said. **PII**

EY GDS launches ey.ai Center for Reimagination

Bengaluru: EY GDS on Thursday launched the ey.ai Center for Reimagination, an immersive flagship client experience centre designed to help organisations experience how emerging tech and industry shifts will reshape industries, workforces and business decisions. It is spread over 40,000 sq ft and located at EY GDS, Bengaluru. **OUR BUREAU**

Deeptech start-up TakeMe2Space to build country’s first star tracker

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

TakeMe2Space (TM2Space), a deeptech start-up building an orbital data centre infrastructure, has announced it is developing StarSense, the country’s first star tracker. It has received approval and backing from the Technology Adoption Fund (TAF) of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe). “Star trackers are the high-precision sensors that let a satellite know exactly where it is pointing, with the single-digit arcsecond accuracy that advanced imaging and communications mis-

India’s green trucking drive hits a cost roadblock

VIABILITY QUESTION.Transporters say they are being asked to shift to EVs costing up to ₹1 cr, while freight contracts are still awarded based on lowest cost

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India’s push toward battery-electric trucking is colliding with a brutal freight-market reality: transporters are being asked to replace ₹35–45 lakh diesel trucks with battery-electric vehicles that can cost ₹80 lakh to more than ₹1 crore, depending on battery size and payload capacity, even as freight contracts continue to be negotiated largely on the lowest cost.

Fleet operators at the Commercial Vehicle Forum (CVF) in Pune said the economics become even harder in a sector where margins are already under pressure from rising diesel prices, financing costs and aggressive freight-rate competition. Unlike diesel trucks, battery-electric trucks also bring charging dependence, reduced route flexibility, uncertain resale values and utilisation risks that directly affect profitability. “We are hearing two mes-

sages at the same time — customers want greener fleets and lower emissions, but freight contracts are still negotiated almost entirely on lowest cost,” said Nikita Gardodia, Chief Operating Officer, Anva Logistics. That mismatch is increasingly forcing transporters to absorb the cost and operational risk of India’s green logistics transition without corresponding changes in freight pricing or customer contracts.

FLEXIBILITY PROBLEM

Fleet operators said the shift to electric trucks is difficult because trucking profitability depends heavily on flexibility and high daily utilisation, both of which become harder with battery-electric vehicles.

“What happens if you cannot redeploy the truck even though it might be physically running?” said Sagarshi Chakraborti, P&L Head, Operations at Let’s Transport, referring to one of the biggest operational concerns



HURDLES AHEAD. Operation of electric trucks also brings charging dependency, lower route flexibility, uncertain resale value and utilisation risk into the picture, say truck operators

around electric trucking. In India’s freight market, trucks are routinely shifted across customers, cities and routes depending on cargo demand. Diesel vehicles can easily be refuelled and reassigned almost anywhere, but battery-electric trucks are often tied to fixed charging corridors and predictable operating cycles. That reduces flexibility for transporters, espe-

cially in long-haul operations where profitability depends on keeping trucks moving with minimal downtime. Executives said the industry’s traditional understanding of total cost of ownership, or TCO, is also changing rapidly. Operators now have to account not just for fuel savings and acquisition costs, but also for financing risk, charging access,

payload impact, downtime and resale uncertainty. Banks and financiers are also approaching electric trucks cautiously because long-term residual values and battery replacement economics remain uncertain, fleet operators said.

ESG VS FREIGHT RATES
Fleet operators said one of the biggest contradictions in

SAT to hear pleas by five offshore funds named in Hindenburg report

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Five offshore funds named in the January 2023 Hindenburg report are scheduled to be heard by the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) on Friday in a case against the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI). Albula Investment Fund, LTS Investment Fund, Cresta Fund, Asia Investment Corporation Mauritius, and APMS Investment Fund are the funds listed to be heard in the tribunal on June 12. All five funds’ plea challenges adjudication proceedings initiated by SEBI against the funds without

taking into account the replies submitted by them to an earlier show-cause notice. The counsels have sought a stay on SEBI’s adjudication action until the matter is closed by the appellate tribunal, said a legal source. The case is linked to SEBI’s wider examination of multiple offshore funds named in the Hindenburg report in 2023 for alleged improper use of tax havens by the group. Last year, the markets regulator issued show-cause notices to several funds seeking explanations regarding alleged breaches of disclosure norms and investment restrictions for group holdings by offshore funds.

FirstClub eyes 50 clubhouses in 6 months, plans expansion beyond Bengaluru

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Quality-focused quick commerce start-up FirstClub is accelerating its expansion plans following a fresh funding round, with the company aiming to scale its network to around 50 clubhouses across Bengaluru and Hyderabad over the next six months while also entering new product categories. It currently operates 24 clubhouses — 21 in Bengaluru and three in Hyderabad — plans to deepen its presence in existing markets before evaluating entry into additional cities. “In Bengaluru, we’ll be



Ayyappan R, Founder and CEO, FirstClub

opening another 10 to 15 clubhouses in the next six months. In Hyderabad, we’ll hit something around 25 clubhouses, so we plan to hit around 50 clubhouses in the next six months,” Ayyappan R, Founder and CEO, First-

Club, told *businessline*. The company recently entered Hyderabad, its first market outside Bengaluru, and says the early response has reinforced its expansion strategy. According to Ayyappan, the latest capital raise will be deployed towards increasing the number of clubhouses, entering new cities and broadening the platform’s category mix. “Any single commerce category that you see, we will be looking at it at some point in time, especially categories where quality matters a lot more. We are working towards launching some of these categories very quickly,” Ayyappan said.

Third Wave Coffee aims to achieve breakeven this fiscal, plans to open 100 new cafés

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

Third Wave Coffee is aiming to achieve company-level break-even in the current financial year as the coffee chain is on an expansion spree and plans to open 100 new cafés this fiscal. The Bengaluru-based coffee chain currently has over 220 stores across the country. The coffee-first QSR brand operates under COCO (company-owned-company-operated) model and does not have any plans to open stores through a franchise model in the near future.

GROWTH PLANS
“We are quite a bit positive as far as unit economics is concerned. We are well funded.



Rajat Luthra, CEO, Third Wave Coffee

So we are expanding our own stores at this point,” Third Wave Coffee CEO Rajat Luthra told *businessline*. “We definitely will open 100 stores during this financial year. We will always have enough funds available to us as and when it is required,” Luthra said. The coffee chain has fo-

ayed into the East with the launch of three new cafés in Kolkata — two in Ballygunge and one in Salt Lake. For strengthening its presence across the city, the company aims to add another five-six stores in Kolkata within the current financial year. “In the East, it is not only Kolkata, we will also be looking at Guwahati, Ranchi, Patna and Bhubaneswar. So, these are the markets we will be looking at in the near future,” he said, adding around 60-70 per cent of the new stores, to be opened in FY27, would be launched in the existing cities the company operates, while the rest 30-40 per cent will come up in new markets. “We will open two to three stores in each of the new markets. Kolkata has a major

role in this as the city should have total stores between 10-12. And, in the remaining cities the company will open a couple of stores,” Luthra said. Currently, the coffee chain has 64 stores in Bengaluru, 48 stores in Delhi NCR, 40 stores in Mumbai, 18 stores in Pune, 13 stores in Hyderabad, and eight stores in Chennai. “At the store-level we are highly EBITDA positive, around 90 per cent of our stores are EBITDA positive. We are trying to break even at the company level this year (FY27). We are very close to it now,” Luthra said. “We use Indian coffee, not importing any coffee from outside. As we are scaling up at present, it is helping us to navigate the cost,” he added.

India can emerge as an AI innovation powerhouse if it gets skilling right: Pearson

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

India’s demographic dividend could turn into a liability if the country fails to build AI-ready talent and foster homegrown innovation, according to Vishaal Gupta, Global President, Enterprise Learning & Skills, and India Chair at Pearson Plc. Speaking to *businessline*, Gupta said India continues to enjoy a significant advantage through its large pool of young talent, but warned that the country risks being left behind if it does not address emerging skill gaps and create globally competitive AI companies. “Today, if you look at the



Vishaal Gupta, Global President, Enterprise Learning & Skills, and India Chair at Pearson Plc

top AI companies globally, none of them is an Indian company. That needs to change,” he said, adding that India has the opportunity to emerge as an innovation powerhouse by developing AI solutions tailored to local challenges before scaling them globally.

While concerns around job losses due to AI persist, Gupta believes the technology will eventually create more jobs than it displaces. He pointed to emerging roles in AI safety, AI ethics and AI integration as examples of new opportunities that are beginning to take shape. The comments come as Pearson doubles down on its enterprise learning and skills business, which the company has identified as one of its key growth drivers. The business grew 13 per cent in Q4 and has built a backlog worth hundreds of millions of dollars through partnerships with technology majors such as Microsoft, AWS, Google, Salesforce and IBM. India is among Pearson’s top seven markets globally

and is seeing strong demand for AI and digital-skilling programmes from multinational technology companies, Indian enterprises and government agencies.

BROADENING REACH
According to Gupta, demand is extending beyond employee training to include skilling partners, customers and broader ecosystems. Pearson is working with multiple government bodies on AI skilling initiatives, including a formal partnership with Telangana’s AI Centre of Excellence. The company is also engaged with governments in Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Delhi and Uttar Pradesh and central government entities, Gupta said.

Blue economy to take center stage at Bharat Innovates 2026 in France



V KAMAKOTI

In June 2026, India will take its top 120 deep-tech ventures to Nice, France, for Bharat Innovates 2026, an initiative of the Ministry of Education of India. This initiative, announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the presence of President Macron, is more than a showcase. It is a declaration. India is no longer just a technology market. It is a technology builder. And among the 13 frontier themes India carries to Nice, one stands out for its sheer scale of opportunity: the Blue Economy. IIT Madras is proud to be the nodal institution for this theme. India has an 11,099-kilometre coastline, 1,298 islands, and an exclusive economic zone of 2.3 million square km. Nearly 95 per cent by volume of the country’s trade moves by sea. Mil-

lions of coastal families depend on the ocean for their livelihoods. India’s ocean economy holds extraordinary promise. The Government has recognised this with clarity and purpose and is now translating that recognition into bold, coordinated policy.

FROM VISION TO POLICY
The Sagarmala Programme is modernising 13 major ports and over 200 minor ports, with 839 identified projects worth about ₹5.8 lakh crore, linking ports to the hinterland and enabling port-led industrialisation. The Deep Ocean Mission is funding scientists to explore the deep sea using the indigenous Matsya submersible, unlocking strategic resources and cutting-edge ocean science. The Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana, with over ₹20,050 crore in approved projects, is transforming fisheries and coastal livelihoods. The PM Gati Shakti framework ties ports, railways, roads, and logistics

into a single digital map. And the Harit Sagor Guidelines are steering India’s ports toward sustainability. The Union Budget 2026–27 proposed the highest-ever annual budgetary support of ₹2,761.80 crore for the fisheries sector. Offshore wind targets of 30 GW by 2030 are being pursued along the Gujarat and Tamil Nadu coasts. India is now openly talking about a \$100 billion blue economy.

RESEARCH FRONTIER
IIT Madras has been building toward this moment for nearly five decades. Our Department of Ocean Engineering, celebrating its Golden Jubilee this year, is home to Asia’s largest shallow-wave basin research facility and seven hydrodynamic test facilities under one roof. Researchers here work on ship hydrodynamics, offshore structures, marine renewable energy, coastal engineering, underwater acoustics, autonomous marine vehicles and more. This is the infrastructure India needs to



COASTAL ADVANTAGE. India has a 11,099 km coastline, 1,298 islands and an exclusive economic zone of 2.3 million sq km. Nearly 95% by volume of the country’s trade moves by sea **KR DEEPAK**

compete in the global ocean economy. The National Technology Centre for Ports, Waterways and Coasts (NTCPWC), hosted at IIT Madras and funded by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, exemplifies research with direct national impact. NTCPWC has completed over 100 projects worth ₹200 crore for major ports and public sector undertakings. In November 2025, it deployed India’s first fully indigenous Vessel Traffic Man-

agement System at the Vizhinjam International Seaport, inaugurated by the Prime Minister. The estimated savings in foreign exchange through indigenous technology over the past five years alone stand at approximately ₹1,500 crore. Our ME2ME Centre of Excellence, funded under the Government’s Institute of Eminence initiative, is building marine autonomous vehicles, testing wave energy devices off the Tamil Nadu coast, and developing AI-

driven tools for port operations and ocean monitoring.

START-UP ECOSYSTEM
Research that stays in the laboratory does not build an economy. At IIT Madras, we have built a culture where research knowledge walks out as companies. Our incubation cell has nurtured 567 startups, incubating 112 new ventures in FY 2025–26 alone across AI, robotics, climate, and ocean technologies. Planys Technologies, founded in 2015 by IIT Madras alumni and faculty, builds Remotely Operated Vehicles and autonomous underwater systems that inspect submerged infrastructure such as bridges, dams, ports, and offshore rigs, using AI diagnostics. It holds 21 granted patents, has logged over 25,000 hours of operational deployment across 500 sites in more than 10 countries, and has raised over ₹100 crore in funding. It is India’s first manufacturer of underwater ROVs, and it started in an IIT Madras laboratory. Another

Bharat Innovates participant, Zerocircle, is a Pune-based startup using seaweed to create biodegradable packaging, linking marine biomass with solutions to plastic pollution. Beyond the start-ups participating in Bharat Innovates 2026 of the Ministry of Education of India, IIT Madras is also strengthening the wider blue-economy entrepreneurship pipeline. Virya Paramita Energy (VPE), a Visakhapatnam-based start-up, co-developed the Sindhuja-1 ocean wave energy converter with IIT Madras researchers under a formal joint development agreement. India’s coastline has an estimated ocean-energy potential of 54 GW, including about 40 GW from wave energy. Sindhuja-1 is a first, tangible step toward harnessing it. IIT Madras has also partnered with Cochin Shipyard Ltd, backed by a ₹50 crore corpus, to build a dedicated funding pipeline and incubation support for maritime start-ups.

FRANCE PARTNERSHIP
France is a natural partner for India in the Blue Economy. France has one of the world’s largest exclusive economic zones, deep expertise in offshore energy and ocean science, and institutions, from IFREMER to NRIA, that complement India’s strengths. The India-France Year of Innovation is the right moment to move from goodwill to collaboration. Joint research in marine renewable energy, offshore technology, and coastal resilience is an obvious starting point. Co-development of deep-sea technologies, where both nations have ambition, but the problems are shared, is another. And for Indian start-ups like those we are bringing to Nice, France offers access to Europe’s innovation markets, funding networks, and industrial partners. We look forward to building, with France and the world, a blue economy worthy of our nations’ ambitions.

The writer is the Director of IIT-Madras

QUICKLY.

Maharashtra backs
Navi Mumbai Medicity

Mumbai: The Maharashtra government, Cleveland Clinic, Brookfield Asset Management and Arohan Health City have signed a memorandum of understanding to develop the Navi Mumbai International MediCity. Under the proposed partnership, Cleveland Clinic will serve as the anchor institution for the project, bringing in its globally recognised expertise in quaternary care, medical education, research, innovation and patient-centric healthcare delivery. **OUR BUREAU**

Nipah infection
confirmed in Kerala

Kozhikode: A Nipah virus infection case has been confirmed in Kozhikode district, prompting the administration to initiate preventive measures. The infection was confirmed in a 43-year-old man from Ramanattukara, and he in the ICU at the Kozhikode Medical College Hospital, said Collector MS Madhavikutty. **PTI**

‘Skilling, planned urbanisation and affordable energy key to Viksit Bharat’

IN FOCUS. Human capital development must align with growth ambitions, says NITI Aayog Vice-Chairman

Asian News International
New Delhi

Skilling, planned urbanisation, and affordable energy emerged as key themes at the 11th Governing Council Meeting of NITI Aayog, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and chief ministers of States underlining the need to align human capital development with India’s long-term growth ambitions, NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri said on Thursday.

He said the discussions covered ‘all aspects of life’ of citizens, including education, healthcare and employment, with a strong emphasis on building a skilled workforce. “It’s very important because a skilled population is the key to success,” he said.

HUMAN CAPITAL
Highlighting the importance



PM Narendra Modi addresses the NITI Aayog Governing Council in New Delhi on Thursday. NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri, Union Ministers Amit Shah, Rajnath Singh and Shivraj Singh Chouhan were present **ANI**

of human capital in economic development, Lahiri said, “A literate population, a healthy population, a well-educated population is the key to success.” Prime Minister and the chief ministers spoke a lot about employment. Here, one of the things that is very important is skilling,” Lahiri added. He noted that industries often face a shortage of suit-

ably trained workers despite the expansion of educational institutions.

SKILL DEVELOPMENT Lahiri stressed that skill development programmes must be guided by industry requirements. “Industry, what do they want? What kind of skills do they want? So a great collaboration between industry and the

The Prime Minister and Chief Ministers talked about making energy prices competitive and energy available, said the Vice-Chairman

skilling institutions is very important,” he said. The meeting also saw extensive discussions on urbanisation and infrastructure planning as India continues to witness rapid migration to cities. “Many chief ministers and the Prime Minister talked about disorderly urbanisation,” Lahiri said, adding that the country’s leadership is “fully aware of the fact that we need planned urbanisation.” According to him, discussions included the develop-

ment of plug-and-play industrial parks supported by housing, roads, sewerage networks, schools and public amenities. Energy affordability and availability were also discussed, particularly the role of renewable and nuclear power in meeting future demand. “Prime Minister and chief ministers talked about the question of making energy prices competitive and energy available,” Lahiri said.

He said members advocated wider adoption of rooftop solar systems in homes, schools, hospitals and government buildings to reduce dependence on grid electricity and ease subsidy burdens.

“There was talk about nuclear energy because many of the members said it’s now safe. The nuclear energy has evolved so much that we don’t need to be worried about another Chernobyl,” he added.

Gujarat to set up space manufacturing hub in Ahmedabad

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The Gujarat government on Thursday said it will develop a dedicated space manufacturing hub near Khoraj in Ahmedabad, along with a common technical facility (CTF) worth up to ₹100 crore to support testing and development of space technologies by start-ups and MSMEs, in collaboration with the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe).

The upcoming space manufacturing park at GIDC Khoraj will act as a shared infrastructure base where companies working in satellites, launch vehicle components and space applications can test and validate their systems without having to build expensive in-house facilities.

The CTF will include a clean room, thermal vacuum chamber, vibration testing system for heavy payloads up to 12 tonnes, EMI/EMC testing setup, climate simulation chambers, mass properties measurement systems, mag-

● **TESTING GROUND**

The ₹100 crore testing facility will support start-ups, MSMEs and satellite technology development across Gujarat

netic field testing infrastructure and optical calibration facilities for Earth observation satellites.

Officials said the model is designed to make it easier for start-ups and smaller com-

panies to enter the space sector by giving them access to high-end testing infrastructure that is typically available only with large organisations.

QUALITY CHECKS The facility is expected to speed up product development, improve quality checks and support end-to-end testing of spacecraft and satellite systems within Gujarat. Under the agreement, IN-SPACe will provide technical support and contribute up to ₹100 crore for equipment, while the Gujarat gov-

ernment will fund construction, operations and development of the larger space manufacturing park. The State has already earmarked 50 acres for the project at GIDC Khoraj, with scope to expand up to 100 acres depending on future demand. The initiative is part of Gujarat’s SpaceTech Policy (2025–30) and is aimed at building a strong space ecosystem around Ahmedabad by attracting startups, manufacturers and research-driven companies working across the space value chain.

Mobile link back on Mumbai Metro Aqua Line

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

In a major relief to Mumbaikars, telcos Vodafone Idea (Vi) and Bharti Airtel have restored mobile network across 16 stations of Mumbai Metro’s Aqua Line. Vi services are live from Aarey JVLR to Acharya Atre Chowk. Science Centre to Cuffe Parade will be connected in the coming weeks, said Vi. Airtel connectivity is now live at 10 metro stations, from Aarey JVLR to BKC.

Prestige to build ₹1,800 cr convention centre at Bangalore Airport City

Siddhi Patil
Bangaluru

Realty major Prestige Group has partnered with Bangalore Airport City Ltd (BACL) to set up a 14.2 acre convention centre and commercial space within the Bangalore Airport City premises. Prestige plans to invest approximately ₹1,800 crore in the project by 2027, with formal inauguration targeted for 2031.

The project comes as airports increasingly seek to transform themselves into integrated business and lifestyle destinations rather than mere transit hubs.

Similar airport-city developments have emerged around Delhi’s Aerocity and GMR Aerocity Hyderabad, combining offices, hotels, retail and entertainment spaces.

The development will add a convention and exhibition

centre, premium retail and cultural spaces, alongside two hospitality properties operated by St Regis and Marriott Marquis, together offering around 500 rooms.

GLOBAL STANDARDS The plan is being conceptualised by the New York-based international architectural firm Kohn Pedersen Fox (KPF), celebrated for global projects such as the Zayed International Airport in Abu Dhabi and the ongoing Terminal 5 expansion at Singapore’s Changi Airport.

Hari Marar, Managing Director and CEO of Bangalore International Airport, noted, “With this convention centre, we’ll see some really high-quality global events coming here, which means that more and more Fortune 500 companies will establish their offices here.”

The writer is an intern

J&K eyes clean plant centre to supply disease-free planting material

bl.interview

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Agriculture Production Minister Javid Ahmad Dar highlighted key challenges facing the Union Territory’s agriculture and horticulture sectors, including the status of a proposed crop insurance scheme, demand for a market intervention mechanism for apple growers, climate change impact, pest infestations, shrinking agricultural land, expansion of high-density apple cultivation and plans to revive the region’s saffron sector.

Edited excerpts:

Jammu and Kashmir does not have an insurance scheme for crops such as apples, litchi and saffron. Why has the government failed to introduce one? We initially attempted to roll out the Restructured



We have constituted a committee to ensure that quarantine protocols are followed properly

JAVID AHMAD DAR
Jammu and Kashmir Agriculture Production Minister



Weather-Based Crop Insurance Scheme and invited bids from insurance companies. However, only one company responded as the challenging weather conditions in Jammu and Kashmir discouraged wider participation. Subsequently, more companies joined the bidding process and the L1 bidder was identified. However, we later received a communication from the Central government regarding revisions to the insurance policy framework, prompting us to put the process on hold. We have already made budgetary provisions for the scheme and

are hopeful it will be introduced in the coming months.

Farmers often complain that there is no Market Intervention Scheme. Why has the government not implemented one? The proposed scheme is primarily aimed at procuring C-grade apples to protect growers from distress sales during periods of price collapse.

Recently, a team from NITI Aayog visited the region and we apprised them of the need for an MIS. The team collected data from various departments, and we believe

the Centre is considering rolling out an MIS for the Himalayan region.

High-density apple cultivation was projected as a game changer for the horticulture sector. Has it achieved the desired results?

High-density apple cultivation has transformed horticulture in many parts of south Kashmir. Under programmes such as the Holistic Agriculture Development Programme, a large number of growers have shifted to high-density and exotic apple varieties. The results have been encouraging in terms of productivity and returns. We are encouraging farmers in north Kashmir to adopt the model as well.

Farmers have reported the emergence of new pests, such as Leaf Miner, associated with imported planting material. What steps is the government taking? Importers and suppliers are

Reward well-performing States, says TN CM Vijay at NITI Aayog meet

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday made a strong pitch for co-operative federalism and greater empowerment of the States, saying a stronger India can only be built through stronger States.

Addressing the 11th Governing Council Meeting of NITI Aayog in New Delhi, Vijay said, “Together, through partnership, mutual respect and shared responsibility, we can build a prosperous, equitable, innovative and sustainable India.”

In his first address at a national forum after assuming office as Chief Minister, Vijay outlined Tamil Nadu’s vision of becoming a \$1.5 trillion economy by 2036. He said the State’s development strategy is anchored on four pillars — youth, the poor, women and farmers — and is closely aligned with the national development agenda.

FISCAL RESPONSIBILITY He said the States that have demonstrated fiscal responsibility, social progress and population stabilisation should be adequately rewarded, and not be placed at a disadvantage.

In a continuity of the stance of the previous DMK government, Vijay reiterated Tamil Nadu’s opposition to the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET), and said the examination had adversely affected students from rural and socio-economically disadvantaged backgrounds. He requested that Tamil Nadu be allowed to fill all State quota seats in MBBS, BDS and AYUSH courses solely on the basis of Class XII marks.

The Chief Minister also requested the sanction of a second AIIMS for Tamil



Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay leaving for the NITI Aayog Governing Council meet from TN House in New Delhi **PTI**

Nadu in Coimbatore, stating that the State government was ready to provide the required land.

He urged the Centre to release pending funds of ₹3,284 crore under the Samagra Shiksha Scheme without conditions and without linking the release to the implementation of the National Education Policy or the three-language policy.

He also urged the Centre to declare the space manufacturing facility being developed at Kulasekarapattinam with IN-SPACe as a National Space Manufacturing Hub.

Highlighting infrastructure needs arising from Tamil Nadu’s rapid economic growth, Vijay sought approval for major projects including the six-laning of the Chengalpattu-Tiruchi stretch of the GST Road (NH-32) and a high-speed rail corridor connecting Chennai and Kanniyakumari.

DIGITAL CONNECTIVITY On digital connectivity, he noted that BharatNet Phase-II in Tamil Nadu had achieved around 97 per cent completion and requested Central support to address the remaining last-mile challenges and ensure sustainable network operations.

required to quarantine planting material before distributing it to farmers. We have constituted a committee to ensure that quarantine protocols are followed properly. In addition, we are working to establish a Clean Plant Centre that will supply disease-free planting material to growers. We have already taken up the matter with the Central government.

Coming to the heritage saffron crop, farmers claim that yields declined sharply last season, while the area under cultivation has fallen from 5,707 hectares to 3,715 hectares. What is the government’s roadmap for reviving the sector? The government launched the National Saffron Mission in 2010-11 with an outlay of ₹400 crore to revive saffron cultivation and improve productivity. While the mission

led to significant interventions, sustained attention is necessary. Many growers are facing rising cultivation costs and labour shortages.

At the same time, several initiatives have been undertaken to strengthen the sector. A Saffron Spice Park has been established at a cost of around ₹37 crore, Kashmiri saffron has received GI status, and large tracts of saffron land have been rejuvenated.

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thehindu businessline.

Score goals, save more: Supplyco launches FIFA World Cup-themed discounts

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

As Kerala gears up for the FIFA World Cup frenzy, football fever is set to extend beyond giant cutouts, fan rallies and television screens to the State’s grocery shelves.

KICK-OFF

To blend the excitement of the world’s biggest football tournament with everyday shopping, the Kerala State Civil Supplies Corporation (Supplyco) has launched ‘Supplyco Soccer Eleven’, a special World Cup-themed promotional campaign offering discounts on popular Sabari products based on the performance of leading football nations. Supplyco, the State government’s public distribution and retail inter-

Supplyco Soccer 11	
Country	Product
Brazil	Turmeric Powder
Germany	Appam Powder
Netherlands	Sambar Powder
Spain	Puttu Powder
Argentina	Payasam Mix
Belgium	Super Fine Dust Tea
Portugal	Chilli Powder
Croatia	Coconut Oil
England	Salt
Morocco	Hotel Blend Tea
France	Gold Tea

vention agency, has designed the scheme to make football fans active participants in the tournament while enjoying savings on essential household products.

Starting June 15, the initiative will link 11 top World

Cup teams with 11 popular Sabari products.

NUMBER OF GOALS

The discount percentage on each product will depend on the number of goals scored by its associated team during the tournament. For instance, if Brazil scores three goals in a match, Sabari turmeric powder, which is linked to Brazil, will be available at a three per cent discount until the start of Brazil’s next match.

DISCOUNT RATE

Once a team is knocked out of the World Cup, the offer linked to it will automatically cease.

If any of the 11 teams wins the tournament, the Sabari product linked to the champion nation will be offered at a special additional discount.

Bankers peg TN FY27 credit flow at ₹11 lakh crore

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Finance Minister N Marie Wilson on Wednesday released the annual credit plan (ACP) for FY 2026–27, which envisions a credit outlay of ₹10.98 lakh crore for Tamil Nadu, at the 186th State Level Bankers’ Committee (SLBC) meeting held on Wednesday.

The credit outlay, a growth of around 12 per cent over the previous year’s target, is allocated to agriculture sector (₹6.5 lakh crore), MSMEs (₹3.97 lakh crore), and other priority sectors.

The Finance Minister said that the State’s banking fraternity beat the FY26 target of ₹9 lakh crore, with credit disbursement of ₹9.8 lakh crore.

At the event, convened by Indian Overseas Bank, Wilson appreciated the banking fraternity for its performance and expressed confidence that the ACP target for the next fiscal year will also be surpassed.

STUDENTS’ FUTURE

He emphasised the importance of educational loans in supporting students’ future, and simultaneously investing in human capital.

IOB General Manager Vijaya N, Chief Secretary of Tamil Nadu’s Finance Department MA Siddique, IOB Executive Director and SLBC Chairman Dhanaraj T and RBI Chief General Manager Rakesh Srivastava were present on the occasion.

This report was filed by intern Mahalakshmi G

Residency Hotels unveils ₹450 cr hotel, convention centre in Madurai

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Residency Hotels, owned by Chennai-based Appasamy Group, a real estate developer, has launched The Residency Signature, a ₹450 crore luxury hotel-convention centre in Madurai with 186 rooms, betting on the city’s potential as a destination for MICE tourism, weddings, large social events and spiritual travel, said Rohit Ravi Appaswamy - MD, The Residency Hotels and Appaswamy Real Estates Ltd.

It will be the 8th hotel from the group, which also owns a hotel in the Maldives managed by Marriott, the St Regis Vommuli Island, he told *businessline*.

QUICKLY.

Glenmark launches Winlevi in Europe



Mumbai: Glenmark Pharmaceuticals has launched its dermatological product Winlevi (clascoterone 10 mg/g cream) in key European markets through its subsidiary Glenmark Specialty SA, the company said. The launch marks a milestone in Glenmark's strategy to grow its dermatology portfolio, besides reflecting its focus on expanding access to differentiated therapies across global markets, it added. The launch follows the marketing authorisation it received for the product, used to treat acne vulgaris in both adults and adolescents aged 12 to 18 years. **OUR BUREAU**

UDAN seaplane service likely to commence operations on June 22

LAKSHADWEEP LINK. SkyHop set to launch Kochi-Agatti service; Civil Aviation Minister expected to inaugurate

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The long-awaited seaplane services under the regional connectivity scheme (UDAN) are likely to commence on June 22, with operations between Kochi and Agatti in Lakshadweep expected to be inaugurated by Civil Aviation Minister Ram-mohan Naidu, sources told *businessline*. Final security clearances for the project have now been received, paving the way for the launch of commercial seaplane operations in the island territory, they said. The development follows a recent communication reviewed by *businessline*, in



GREEN SIGNAL. Final security clearances for the project have now been received

which the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) recommended that seaplane operations in Lakshadweep be permitted under a security framework similar to that applicable to helicopter operations. "The operations of seaplanes from Lakshadweep islands may be undertaken on the lines of helicopter operations already taking place under the control of State police security and arrangements in other places of India," the communication stated. However, the document also cautioned that the unique nature of seaplane operations and water aerodromes could result in delays owing to security and infrastructure requirements. "Standardisation of water

aerodrome security at par with regular civil aviation operations, therefore, would require a range of measures and technologies designed to ensure the safety and protection of seaplanes and associated facilities," the document said. The communication further clarified that the relaxation is being considered a location-specific measure and is applicable only to seaplane operations in Lakshadweep. **SECURITY REVIEW** Besides, BCAS noted that while it is in the process of formulating comprehensive security requirements for seaplane operations and water aerodromes across the country, the unique con-

nectivity needs of the island territory warrant an interim arrangement. Accordingly, it recommended that seaplane services in Lakshadweep be permitted under security arrangements similar to those applicable to helicopter operations until a broader regulatory framework is put in place. Furthermore, sources said that SkyHop Aviation will operate the services under the UDAN scheme. Recently, SkyHop Aviation received its Air Operator Certificate (AOC). *businessline* was the first to report in April that SkyHop Aviation was expected to receive its flying licence after successfully completing regulatory trials.

TCS, Anthropic announce strategic deal to accelerate adoption of enterprise AI

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai



Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) on Thursday announced a global partnership with Anthropic AI to scale enterprise AI adoption through early access to Claude models via a business unit. Noting that in regulated industries, most AI initiatives stall at the pilot stage, TCS will bring Claude models to enterprises that demand accuracy, deep integration, resilience and strong governance. **PRACTICAL PATH** Combining scaled internal deployment, joint go-to-market offerings, industry co-innovation and work-force enablement, the partnership gives clients a practical path to enterprise-wide adoption and measurable outcomes. TCS will equip 50,000 associates across engineering, finance, legal, marketing and sales with Claude through enterprise-wide licensing. By deploying Claude internally, TCS will gain first-hand experience to transform its own operations while applying those insights to drive client success. Both TCS and Anthropic will jointly go to market with AI solutions and services across industries including highly-regulated sectors, such as financial services, public services, life sciences, healthcare, aviation, telecom and medtech. K Krithivasan, CEO and Managing Director at TCS, said, "By combining Claude with our industry expertise, engineering rigour and largescale transformation capabilities, we will help customers move faster to production, especially in industries where trust, resilience and regulatory discipline are critical."

Dario Amodei, Co-founder and CEO, Anthropic, said, "This partnership deepens our commitment to India, our second-largest market, with TCS bringing Claude to enterprises and professionals across the region and globally, including 50,000 of its employees."

SHARED CONVICTION N Chandrasekaran, Chairman, Tata Sons, said, "It reflects our shared conviction that AI will be foundational and transformative for enterprises worldwide. By combining Anthropic's capabilities with Tata Group's scale, trusted relationships, and nation-building commitment, we will accelerate enterprise reinvention and equip India's youth with the skills to lead in the AI era." While prior platform waves in the Indian IT industry expanded the billable hour, this is the first platform wave in the industry's history whose explicit design purpose is to compress the labour it is hired to deploy, said Greyhound Research. "TCS is not merely distributing Anthropic's technology. It is distributing the deflation of its own pricing unit," pointed out Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst and Founder at Greyhound Research. He also pointed out that Anthropic comes off as the real winner as it gains is enterprise distribution at a scale no model vendor can build alone.

Ahmedabad crash probe 'not fair', says pilot association

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad



TRANSPARENCY CALL. FIP urged investigators to prioritise accuracy over timelines before releasing any final findings

A year after the Air India Boeing 787 crash in Ahmedabad claimed 260 lives, a pilots' body has questioned the fairness and direction of the investigation, alleging that key evidence is not being followed and lapses in the probe are fueling speculation instead of closure. The Federation of Indian Pilots (FIP) on Thursday said critical questions surrounding the disaster remain unanswered, citing "investigative gaps" ranging from the delayed examination of the sole survivor to concerns over the handling of technical evidence. According to FIP President Captain CS Randhawa,

Vishwash Kumar Ramesh, the lone survivor of the crash, was formally interviewed by investigators only about 10 months after the accident. **TECHNICAL EVIDENCE** The federation questioned whether all available technical evidence, including aircraft communication mes-

sages transmitted before departure, had been adequately examined and whether sufficient independent aviation experts had been involved in the probe. "We are almost completing one year, and there is still no conclusion. We have been unable to investigate a flight that crashed seconds after take-off. So much time and

effort has gone into the probe, yet there is no finality. Investigators are expected to share a draft report 30-60 days before the final report but till date no draft has been circulated," Randhawa said during an interaction with mediapersons in Ahmedabad on Thursday. He questioned the decision to send the aircraft's two black boxes to the US for analysis, alleging that it contradicted claims that India possessed the capability to decode and examine flight recorders domestically. "We have informed the Ministry that this is not a fair investigation that is happening, and time and again things are being done in an inappropriate manner, which is leading to speculation, and investigations are not proceeding as per the

evidence given," the FIP President said. He said FIP officials will meet the families of those killed in the crash on Friday. **TECHNICAL FINDINGS** The pilots' body also alleged that Aircraft Communications Addressing and Reporting System messages transmitted by the aircraft shortly before departure had not been adequately addressed in the preliminary findings. According to Randhawa, several messages were sent approximately 15 minutes before take-off, but there was no mention of them in the preliminary report. Another concern flagged by the federation concerned the composition of the investigation team. Randhawa alleged that the inquiry had not sufficiently

relied on independent subject matter experts, despite the technical complexity of the crash, and questioned the presence of officials from the aviation regulator on the investigation board. Randhawa cautioned against releasing any interim findings before the investigators reach a definitive conclusion. "An interim report at this stage will only add to confusion and fuel further speculation," he said, adding that the Federation of Indian Pilots had urged both the government and the AIIB to refrain from issuing a partial report. "If investigators need more time to establish the facts, the final report can be delayed. Accuracy is more important than meeting a timeline," he said.

Air India crash report may take a few more months to complete: Sources

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The final investigation report into the Air India AI171 crash may take another two to three months to be completed, sources familiar with the probe told *businessline*. "The investigation is well on track for a comprehensive report. It will be placed in the public domain following all due processes. The investigation is well on track for a comprehensive report. It will be placed in the public domain following all due processes. Nothing will be kept in the dark," a source close to the investigation process said. **MORE TIME** A second source, familiar with the developments, said the final report is unlikely to be ready by the first anniversary of the crash (June 12, 2026) and may require another two to three months before being completed. "Owing to the West Asia

The investigation is well on track for a comprehensive report. It will be placed in the public domain following all due processes

crisis, as well as other issues, the probe has faced certain challenges, but it is well on track," the second source said. "The relevant authorities are monitoring the process on a daily basis. However, a complete hands-off approach has been maintained since it is an independent investigation." Notably, these comments come as June 12 marks one year since the Air India AI171 accident, which has been described as one of the

deadliest aviation disasters in recent years. Meanwhile, some industry observers had expected that authorities could issue either a substantive update or the final investigation report around the first anniversary of the accident. However, sources familiar with the process said there is no international obligation requiring investigators to publish their final findings exactly one year after an accident. As per established global aviation investigation practices, agencies are encouraged to release a final report within 12 months wherever practical. **INQUIRY IN PROGRESS** If the inquiry remains in progress, sources said then the investigators may instead provide an update on the status of the investigation

and the work completed so far. At present, sources said investigators are continuing to examine all available evidence and remain focused on ensuring that the final report is thorough, evidence-based and technically rigorous before its release. Till now, the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has maintained that the inquiry into the AI171 crash remains active. Earlier, the AAIB had clarified in its preliminary report that the observations contained in the document were based on evidence available at that stage of the investigation. The preliminary investigation report into the Air India AI171 crash has revealed that both engines of the Boeing 787-8 aircraft shut down within seconds of take-off, leading to the fatal accident that claimed 260 lives.

Zee unveils FIFA World Cup subscription plans

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai



Gearing up for the 26th edition of the FIFA World Cup, Zee Entertainment has announced its all-access subscription pack for the series on its OTT platform ZEE5, starting at a quarterly fee of ₹799. The all-access pack provides users with FIFA live streaming along with all the other contents on ZEE5, as per a blog post. Other plans or bundled offerings will not include livestreaming of the soccer event but users can upgrade to their preferred access pack as and when needed. The pack comes in two alternatives: a three-month plan and a yearly plan of ₹1,699. The three-month plan allows live viewing of

the FIFA World Cup 2026 during the main football season but includes ads. Meanwhile, the yearly plan provides a "largely ad-free" experience barring some live channels. For its linear broadcasting, Zee will charge a monthly fee of ₹7 on Unite8 Sports 1 and ₹9 for its HD version. The other channel Unite8 Sports 2 will charge ₹8 on a monthly basis and ₹11 for its HD streaming. Earlier, match-viewing was free on Reliance Jio's

platform. However, subscription revenues are expected to be the most important monetisation driver for Zee for the FIFA rights package, as per Elara Securities. Zee's acquisition, estimated at ₹260-330 crore by the brokerage, is around 40-50 per cent lower than the previous cycle. "Assuming an effective blended ARPU of around ₹400 per subscriber across monthly and annual plans, ZEE would need to add approximately 2.5-3 million incremental subscribers to recover an annualised rights cost of roughly ₹150 crore. This estimate excludes additional spending towards marketing, channel promotion, distribution and ecosystem building, which could potentially increase the total investment commitment by another 20-30 per cent," said

Elara Securities in its research note. **SCREENING DEALS** In preparation to the match, Zee also established screening partnerships to Novex Communications, Eagles FC Kerala, Zion Bridge, and What's up Goa to facilitate official public viewing opportunities. These partners will work with venues and establishments for legal and authorised screening of FIFA World Cup 2026 matches. Further, Zee has partnered with PVR INOX and Cinepolis to bring select FIFA World Cup 2026 matches to cinema screens. The public viewing rights will allow cinemas, pubs, restaurants, clubs, gymkhanas, airports, educational institutions and hotels to host official screenings of FIFA World Cup 2026 matches.

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